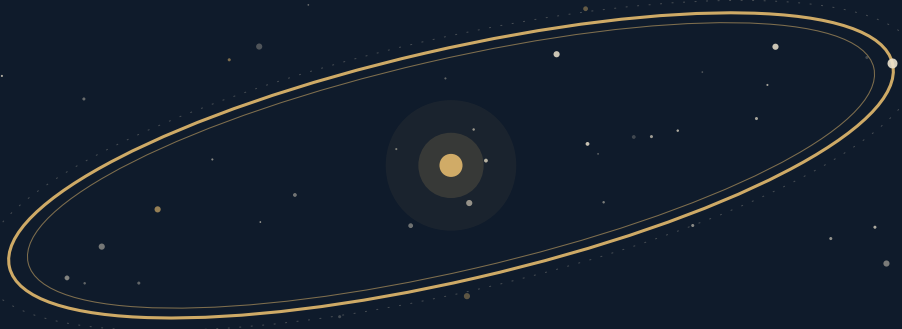
A DOCTORAL THESIS





CONSIDERATIO

The Phlebian Remainder and the General Economy of Utopia in Iain M. Banks's **Consider Phlebas**

O you who turn the wheel and look to windward



OCTOBER 2026

Gentile or Jew
O you who turn the wheel and look to windward,
Consider Phlebas, who was once handsome and tall as you.

T. S. ELIOT, *The Waste Land*, IV, "DEATH BY WATER" (1922)

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Abstract

Iain M. Banks's *Consider Phlebas* (1987), the inaugural novel of the Culture sequence, introduces the most fully elaborated post-scarcity utopia in late twentieth-century speculative fiction through the consciousness of its declared enemy. Its protagonist, Bora Horza Gobuchul, is a metamorphic Changer in the service of the theocratic Idiran Empire, whose quest to seize a fugitive Culture Mind ends in comprehensive failure and is finally reduced, by the novel's historiographical appendices, to a minor incident within a war of galactic magnitude. Criticism has read this architecture as a strategy of hostile focalisation, as a deconstruction of space-operatic heroism, or as anti-war satire. This thesis contends that such readings, while accurate, are partial: the novel constitutes a sustained theoretical intervention into the question of what a civilisation that has abolished scarcity does with whatever exceeds its measure, namely surplus energy, surplus death, surplus meaning, and the surplus subject who refuses abundance.

The argument proceeds by reconstructing the novel's genealogies: T. S. Eliot's "Death by Water" and the Qur'anic epigraph; the anarcho-communist and post-scarcity lineage running from More, Wilde, Kropotkin and Marx to Bookchin; and the anti-machine tradition extending from Samuel Butler to Frank Herbert. It then reads the novel's figures (the Changer, the Idirans, and the Culture's agent, Referrer and Mind) and its economies (the picaresque of waste, the game of Damage, the Planet of the Dead) through Hume's circumstances of justice, Bataille's general economy, Hegelian and post-Hegelian theories of tragedy, Schmitt's political theology, and the Nietzschean–Kojèvian problematic of the last man.

From this apparatus the thesis advances an original synthesis organised around two coinages. The *Phlebian remainder* names the unexchangeable loss that a civilisation without profit and loss cannot metabolise internally and therefore produces, encounters, or expels at its perimeter. Its starkest instance is the Planet of the Dead itself: when a Culture ship is finally admitted, more than forty years after Horza's mission, the tunnels are in perfect repair and there is no trace of any body, so that the mission's dead survive only in the Culture's ledger and in the name a Mind chooses to carry. *Consideratio*, after the Latin *considerare*, whose probable root is *sidus* (star), names the ethical and epistemic labour of holding that remainder in view: a labour the Culture delegates to its calculating Minds but which the novel returns, as an imperative, to its reader. Its model within the fiction is the Referrer Fal 'Ngeestra, who keeps returning, half-embarrassed, to

the thought that the small and the vast matter equally, and who is implicated in what she considers, having herself proposed the agent Balveda for the mission.

Three theorems follow. The theorem of displacement holds that once the Humean circumstances of justice are abolished, justice migrates outward into war and backward into retrospective accounting. The theorem of expenditure holds that post-scarcity intensifies rather than resolves Bataille's problem of the accursed share: both powers spend worlds, the Idirans fusion-bombing cities of Sorpen in the same operation that rescues a single agent, the Culture evacuating the Orbital Vavatch before destroying it. The theorem of mimetic remainder holds that the subject constituted against abundance can be someone only by being someone else; Horza, who fights the Culture's machines on behalf of life, serves a power whose word for humanoids, "biotomaton", classes him as a biological automaton. The thesis concludes that Banks inverts the formal grammar of the utopian genre, relegating utopia to interlude and elevating its perimeter to narrative, and that *Consider Phlebas* thereby founds a mode best described as *perimeter tragedy*, in which the last labour that automation cannot absorb is the consideration of the drowned.

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Note on Texts, Citation, and Method

References to *Consider Phlebas* are to the first edition (London: Macmillan, 23 April 1987). Because pagination diverges across the Macmillan, Futura, Orbit and Little, Brown printings, the novel is cited by its own divisions: the Prologue; fourteen titled chapters, from "Sorpen" to "Consider Phlebas"; the three interludes headed "State of play"; the "Interlude in darkness"; the appendices "Reasons: the Culture", "Reasons: the Idirans" and "The war, briefly"; the "Dramatis personae"; and the Epilogue. Banks's 1994 essay "A Few Notes on the Culture", circulated on Usenet and widely mirrored, is cited by title.

Because the primary text remains in copyright, direct quotation from Banks is held to a handful of short phrases and his prose is otherwise paraphrased. Works in the public domain, including Eliot's *The Waste Land* (1922), Shakespeare, Hobbes, Hume, Wilde, Butler, Forster, Conrad, Melville, and the Common, Garnett and Maude translations of Nietzsche, Dostoevsky and Tolstoy, are quoted freely. Other continental and classical texts are cited from the standard English translations listed under Works Cited.

The method combines three procedures: a philological reading of the paratext; a genealogical reconstruction of the novel's ideas; and a comparative typology across utopian, anti-utopian and military speculative fiction. Throughout, the thesis distinguishes *documented genealogy*, where Banks named a source or a book he repeatedly cited as formative, from *structural affinity*, where the comparison is the critic's instrument rather than the author's inheritance. Bataille, Hume, Schmitt, Hegel and their successors belong to the second category; Eliot, Lucretius, Shakespeare, Melville, Tolstoy, Stapledon, Clarke, Le Guin, Herbert, Huxley, Vonnegut, Heller, Borges, Michael Herr and Robert Mason belong to the first.

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Introduction

The Drowned Sailor and the Shore

The first published novel of the Culture sequence is built so that the reader enters utopia through the eyes of a man who wants it destroyed. We follow him through a sequence of escalating catastrophes and watch him receive his death wound beneath a planet preserved as a monument to self-annihilation. Meanwhile the object of his quest, a fugitive Culture Mind, survives, is restored to the civilisation he despised, and in the novel's closing pages is revealed to have taken his name. No other foundational utopian text in the Anglophone tradition is arranged this way. More's Hythloday, Bellamy's Julian West, Morris's William Guest and Wells's Voice of the Owner are guests, converts or sympathetic sceptics; Bora Horza Gobuchul is an enemy combatant, and the narrative never grants him the conversion that the visitor-utopia exists to stage.

The historical conjuncture sharpens the provocation. Iain Banks (1954–2013) had established himself with *The Wasp Factory* (1984), *Walking on Glass* (1985) and *The Bridge* (1986), and *Consider Phlebas*, the first book to carry the middle initial that would mark his science fiction, was by his own account a reworking of a draft composed in 1984. It appeared in April 1987, two months before Margaret Thatcher's third general-election victory and six months before the *Woman's Own* interview, published on 31 October 1987, in which she denied that there is any such thing as society. Within the same autumn the October crash rendered the vocabulary of profit and loss newly lurid. Into this setting Banks introduced a civilisation that is, in a precise sense, nothing *but* society: it has no state, no money, no market, no law in the juridical sense, and no scarcity. It is administered, to the extent that it is administered at all, by benevolent artificial intelligences. Banks, a lifelong socialist and declared atheist whose opposition to war was not merely literary (in March 2003 he destroyed his passport and posted the remains to 10 Downing Street in protest at Britain's part in the invasion of Iraq, and in 2004 he backed the campaign to impeach Tony Blair), would later defend the economic premise of this civilisation in "A Few Notes on the Culture" (1994), arguing that a planned economy can be both more productive and more morally desirable than the market. There he characterised the market as "a crude and essentially blind system", incapable of telling the mere non-use of matter apart from the sustained suffering of conscious beings. That distinction between surplus matter and suffering minds is, this thesis will argue, the hidden axis of the novel.

Banks was explicit about what the book was written against. He described it as a deliberate rebuff to American science fiction, refusing both the trilogy as a commercial form and the convention that a dynamic protagonist must be the moral centre; in his own words, "Horza isn't the good guy because the Culture is the side of good." He located the second half of the novel in the London Underground, recalling the singing of the rails and the draught of an approaching train. He insisted that the book adopted the grunt's point of view, and that it could not have been written without Michael Herr's *Dispatches* (1977) and Robert Mason's *Chickenhawk* (1983), two testimonies of the American war in Vietnam. In a 1994 interview he explained that the appendices narrating the aftermath of the war were an attempt to pose the question "What was it all for?", and to resist the genre's fantasy that a lone individual determines the direction of civilisations. He also disclaimed any interest in deconstruction. The present thesis takes that disclaimer seriously. It reads *Consider Phlebas* not as an unravelling of space opera but as a construction: a theory, articulated through narrative form, of what a civilisation without scarcity owes to, and does with, its losses.

The critical record has prepared the ground without occupying it. Early reviewers found the book sprawling: *Kirkus Reviews* judged it overextended yet gripping in places, while Dave Langford in *White Dwarf* relished its finale in a deep-shelter system of nuclear trains. Academic criticism has moved along four lines. The first concerns genre and postmodernity: Christopher Palmer (1999) grouped Banks with Dan Simmons as practitioners of a galactic-empire "extravaganza" that proceeds by "critique by overload rather than by irony". The second concerns utopian status, whether the Culture is a utopia at all, a question several critics have pressed (Duggan surveys the contributions of William Hardesty and Simon Guerrier) and which Farah Mendlesohn's account (2005) of the dialectic between decadence and utopia in the Culture novels pursues. The third concerns geopolitics: Robert Duggan (2007) read *Consider Phlebas* and *Look to Windward* against the Gulf War, and Patricia Kerslake (2007) placed the Culture within the imperial imaginary of the genre. The fourth is monographic and synthetic, represented by Simone Caroti (2015) and Paul Kincaid (2017), with more recent work by Mirka Horová (2022) on play and empire. Palmer's emphasis on overload and excess is the nearest precursor of the argument advanced here. Where he treats excess as an aesthetic strategy of the postmodern, this thesis treats it as the object of the novel's political economy and ethics.

The central claim can now be stated. *Consider Phlebas* asks what happens to loss in a civilisation that has abolished the mechanisms through which loss is ordinarily priced, distributed and forgotten. Its answer is that loss does not disappear. It is displaced to the perimeter, where it accumulates as an unexchangeable residue that this thesis names the *Phlebian remainder*, after Eliot's drowned Phoenician, who has "forgot ... the profit and loss". The remainder takes three forms, each governed by a theorem. Justice, deprived of its Humean circumstances, migrates outward into war and backward into retrospective accounting (the theorem of displacement). Surplus, far from being pacified by abundance, must be spent, and is spent most catastrophically in war (the theorem of expenditure). The subject who refuses abundance can sustain a self only by impersonating others, so that his identity becomes a residue of masks (the theorem of mimetic remainder).

Against all three the novel sets an ethical practice that this thesis names *consideratio*: the labour of holding the remainder in view, which the Culture delegates to calculating Minds and the novel, through its title's imperative, returns to the reader.

Two formal consequences follow and will be defended in detail. First, Banks inverts the grammar of the utopian genre: the interior of utopia, seen only in the brief "State of play" interludes, becomes parenthetical, while its perimeter (the battlefield, the derelict, the doomed Orbital, the Planet of the Dead) becomes the narrative proper. Utopia is relocated into the interlude. Second, the novel founds what this thesis calls *perimeter tragedy*: tragedy that persists in the most optimistic of settings, not by refuting the utopia but by being expelled to its edges, where the cost of abundance is paid by those who stand outside it.

The argument is organised in five parts. Part I reconstructs the genealogies of the novel's title, its civilisation and its machines. Part II reads its figures: the Changer, the Idirans, and the three "bodies" through which the Culture appears. Part III analyses its economies of waste, play and memorial. Part IV examines its ends: justice, tragedy, and the fate of the last man. Part V presents the synthesis in full, followed by a comparative coda and a conclusion that returns, by way of *Look to Windward*, to the sea.

I

PART ONE
Genealogies

Part I reconstructs the three lineages from which *Consider Phlebas* is assembled. Chapter 1 reads the paratext (Eliot's "Death by Water", the Qur'anic epigraph, and the grammar of the title) as a compressed argument about loss, idolatry and the reader's obligation. Chapter 2 situates the Culture within the anarchist, communist and post-scarcity traditions, and isolates the respect in which Banks breaks with all of them: his is a utopia of excess rather than of sufficiency. Chapter 3 places the Minds within the long literary war between humanism and the machine, from Samuel Butler to Frank Herbert, and shows how the novel reverses its polarities.

I

Death by Water

Eliot, the Qur'an, and the Paratextual Machine

The paratext of *Consider Phlebas* is argument, not ornament. Its title, its two epigraphs and its relation to the later *Look to Windward* compress, before the first sentence of the Prologue, the novel's entire theory of loss.

1.1 An imperative title

Of the ten Culture books, only two carry titles in the imperative mood, and both are cut from the same three lines of Eliot. *Consider Phlebas* (1987) and *Look to Windward* (2000) are the two novels of the Idiran War. Every other title in the sequence names a person, an object, a condition or a form: *The Player of Games*, *Use of Weapons*, *Excession*, *Inversions*, *Matter*, *Surface Detail*, *The Hydrogen Sonata*. Alone among the sequence's subjects, the war is addressed to the reader as a command. The source is the fourth and shortest section of *The Waste Land*, whose closing three lines Banks set as the novel's second epigraph:

> *Phlebas the Phoenician, a fortnight dead,*
> *Forgot the cry of gulls, and the deep sea swell*
> *And the profit and loss.*
> *A current under sea*
> *Picked his bones in whispers. As he rose and fell*
> *He passed the stages of his age and youth*
> *Entering the whirlpool.*
> *Gentile or Jew*
> *O you who turn the wheel and look to windward,*
> *Consider Phlebas, who was once handsome and tall as you.*

The section falls into two movements. The first seven lines narrate a dissolution. The drowned man forgets, in ascending order of abstraction, a sensation (the cry of gulls), a medium (the swell of the sea) and a system (the profit and loss); the current then strips his bones and replays his life as he rises and falls. The last three lines turn from narration to apostrophe, addressing the living, specifically the steersman, and commanding them to contemplate the corpse as a figure of their own future.

Consider Phlebas reproduces this bipartite structure at the scale of the book. The main narrative is the dissolution. Horza passes through the stages of age and youth: he is trapped in the withered body of a Sorpen Gerontocrat in the early chapters, and later wears the body of the mercenary captain he kills, circling in the whirlpool of a war he cannot steer. The appendices and the dramatis personae are the apostrophe. They turn from the drowned man to the living, address the reader with the arithmetic of the war, and ask what the death was for.

The middle term of the first movement deserves the emphasis Eliot gave it by isolating it on a short line. To forget the profit and loss is to exit economy. For the drowned Phoenician that exit is death; for the citizens of the Culture it is the ordinary condition of life, since a civilisation without money, prices or scarcity has collectively forgotten the profit and loss. The title's irony is therefore structural. Horza's indictment of the Culture, that its humans are spiritually empty dependants of their machines and an evolutionary dead end, amounts to the charge that its citizens are, in Eliot's sense, a fortnight dead: drowned in abundance, beyond the reckonings by which life had been measured. The novel's question is whether the post-economic condition is death or a new form of life. Its method is to make the reader consider a man who answered that question wrongly, with his own body.

1.2 The Phoenician without his tin

The figure has a prehistory in Eliot's own French. The closing section of "Dans le Restaurant" (1918) presents "Phlébas, le Phénicien", a fortnight drowned, forgetting the gulls, the Cornish swell, the profits and the losses, "et la cargaison d'étain": the cargo of tin. Transposing the passage into English for *The Waste Land*, Eliot removed the tin and the Cornish coast, the commodity and its route, and left the merchant with nothing but the abstraction of his ledger. The revision performs, in miniature, a dematerialisation of commerce: the Phoenician is reduced from a carrier of goods to a bearer of accounts. Banks's Culture completes the operation from the opposite side. It retains matter in effectively unlimited supply and abolishes the ledger.

Eliot's notes also make the sailor a node in a system of metamorphoses. In the note to line 218 he writes that "the one-eyed merchant, seller of currants, melts into the Phoenician Sailor, and the latter is not wholly distinct from Ferdinand Prince of Naples, so all the women are one woman, and the two sexes meet in Tiresias." Tiresias, changer of sex and blind seer, is described there as "a mere spectator" who is nonetheless "the most important personage in the poem, uniting all the rest." Banks's protagonist is a Changer in the literal, biological sense: a member of a species able to remodel its body, over days, into the likeness of another. He is the novel's Tiresian node, the single

consciousness through which mercenaries, Idirans, the Culture's agent and the doomed of Vavatch are perceived. The difference is decisive. Eliot's Tiresias suffers everything and acts on nothing; Horza refuses to be a spectator, and would rather drown than watch.

The tarot of Madame Sosostris completes the prophecy. "Here, said she, / Is your card, the drowned Phoenician Sailor, / (Those are pearls that were his eyes. Look!)"; and a few lines later: "Fear death by water." The novel takes the warning literally. Its first chapter opens with Horza, unmasked while impersonating a member of Sorpen's ruling Gerontocracy, sentenced by the Gerontocracy to die in a sewer cell, the effluent of his captors rising towards his mouth; Balveda had argued for leniency, on the ground that Changers are rare. He is rescued by the Idirans, whose force destroys several of Sorpen's cities with fusion bombs in the same operation. Banks himself drew attention to the anomaly: his dynamic hero does not fight his way out but is pulled from the sewer. The death by water is deferred, not cancelled, and the remainder of the novel is the long interval of that deferral.

1.3 Sea-change

Sosostris's parenthesis imports the oldest English mythography of transfiguration by drowning, Ariel's song from *The Tempest*:

> *Full fathom five thy father lies;*
> *Of his bones are coral made;*
> *Those are pearls that were his eyes:*
> *Nothing of him that doth fade*
> *But doth suffer a sea-change*
> *Into something rich and strange.*

The verb compressed into the name of Horza's species finds its archetype here: the drowned body that does not decay but is transmuted. *The Tempest* also supplies the novel's deep triad of magus, spirit and native. Prospero's art is technology in all but name; Ariel is the indentured intelligence that executes it, released at last with "Then to the elements / Be free, and fare thou well!"; Caliban, taught language, reckons that his "profit on't / Is, I know how to curse." Horza stands to the Culture as Caliban to Prospero. He has been given the vocabulary of the galaxy's most advanced civilisation, and he uses it to curse.

Banks reverses the moral valence of the indenture. In Shakespeare the spirit serves and longs to be free. In the Culture the Minds are already free, and it is the humans whom Horza imagines to be enthralled. The anxiety latent in every servant-intelligence fable from Ariel onward, that the spirit will one day slip its bonds, becomes in Horza the conviction that it has already done so, and has kept its former masters as dependants. The novel never confirms that conviction, but it never quite dissolves it either; that irresolution is one source of its enduring unease.

1.4 The drowned god who does not rise

Eliot's notes direct the reader to Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920) and to the Adonis, Attis and Osiris volumes of Frazer's *The Golden Bough*. Among the rites Frazer recounts is the Alexandrian committal of the image of Adonis to the sea, in the expectation of the god's return with the year. Eliot's Phlebas is that god without the return: a vegetation deity stranded in the modern waste land.

Banks redistributes the myth. Two bodies descend into the Command System beneath Schar's World: the Changer, and the Mind, which has concealed itself in the reactor car of a subterranean train. Only one rises alive. The god who returns is the machine. The man dies on the surface, after Balveda has hauled him up, and his resurrection is purely nominal: the Mind, which went on to serve in General Systems Vehicles during the war and after it, bears the name Bora Horza Gobuchul. Banks secularises the vegetation rite twice over. The renewal of the year is replaced by the continuation of the war, and the god's return by the persistence of a proper name in the registry of a machine civilisation. Whether that persistence is memorial, trophy or penance is the question with which this thesis will close.

1.5 Idolatry and carnage

The first epigraph reads "Idolatry is worse than carnage", attributed to "The Koran, 2: 190". In the Cairo numbering now standard, the clause (*wa-l-fitnatu ashaddu mina l-qatl*) stands at 2:191; the discrepancy reflects the variant verse divisions of older European editions. The wording follows N. J. Dawood's Penguin translation (1956). Other translators render *fitna* as persecution, as tumult and oppression, or as sedition, and the word spans a field (trial, temptation, discord, civil strife) that later came to name the civil wars of early Islam. Dawood's choice turns a verse about the persecution of believers into a verse about false worship, and it is in this converted sense that the epigraph enters the novel.

Within the fiction it is, first, Idiran theology. In "State of play: three", the Referrer Fal 'Ngeestra imagines how the Culture must appear to its enemy: a mongrel civilisation tampering with its own heredity and with the development of other peoples, and, worst of all, surrendering itself to the Minds, which from the Idiran standpoint are the image of life itself desecrated, idolatry made flesh. In the same meditation she concedes that the Culture cannot say where it begins or ends, whereas the Idirans know exactly who they are. The epigraph thus names the Idiran casus belli and, in the same breath, the Culture's ontological insecurity.

A comparative proposition, however, is reversible, and its form matters as much as its content. To say that X is worse than carnage is to place a crime against belief and a crime against bodies on a single scale and rank them: it is an act of accounting. The novel ends with a second act of accounting of identical form. Balveda's revival criterion, recorded in the dramatis personae, weighs the carnage of the war against the counterfactual carnage of unchecked Idiran expansion. The secular civilisation does not abandon the comparative. It substitutes a counterfactual death toll for idolatry as the term against which actual carnage is measured. Between the two epigraphs, then, the

novel's ethical problem is fully posed. One epigraph ranks carnage below a metaphysical evil; the other dissolves all ranking into the indifference of the drowned, who have forgotten the profit and loss. The narrative unfolds in the space between the scale and its abolition.

1.6 The wheel and the windward

The apostrophe begins with a universal address, "Gentile or Jew", that echoes the Pauline abolition of confessional difference ("There is neither Jew nor Greek", Galatians 3:28) and anticipates the Culture's indifference to origins. It continues with a vocative, "O you who turn the wheel", whose referents multiply. The wheel is the helm of a ship; it is also the Wheel of Fortune in Sosostris's pack ("Here is the man with three staves, and here the Wheel"), and the wheel of the Buddha's Fire Sermon, which gives its title to the section of *The Waste Land* immediately preceding "Death by Water". For Banks's reader it acquires a fourth referent: the Orbital, the Culture's characteristic habitat, a ring millions of kilometres in circumference, spun for gravity and governed by a Hub Mind. The Culture is literally a civilisation of those who turn the wheel. Read through the novel, the apostrophe addresses the Culture itself, warning its steersmen with the corpse of their enemy.

"Look to windward" is the steersman's vigilance: to face the quarter from which weather, danger and news arrive. Banks took the title of his later novel from it. *Look to Windward* is set on the Masaq' Orbital as the light of two stars destroyed in the Idiran War finally reaches it, centuries after the fact, and its subject is commemoration and guilt. The two titles therefore bracket the war with the two imperatives of a single sentence: consider the dead; face the direction from which the past returns. Banks's return to the war thirteen years after the first novel is itself an instance of the practice this thesis calls consideratio: a book written in the delayed light of its predecessor.

1.7 Vein and star: a philology of the title

Phlebas is, as far as can be established, Eliot's coinage, with no attested classical bearer. Its Greek resonance with *phleps*, *phlebos* (vein), whence phlebotomy, invites a reading the poem does not authorise but the novel rewards. Hobbes, in the twenty-fourth chapter of *Leviathan* (1651), calls money the blood of the commonwealth. Its circulation is "the Sanguification of the Commonwealth", for "naturall Bloud is in like manner made of the fruits of the Earth; and circulating, nourisheth by the way, every Member of the Body of Man." A civilisation without money is, in Hobbes's physiology, a Leviathan without blood, and Horza's revulsion at the Culture as sterile mechanism is a Hobbesian intuition in this precise sense. Chapter 13 will argue that the war is the phlebotomy of that bloodless body: a bloodletting performed at its perimeter.

The verb of the title has a richer philology still. Latin *considerare* is plausibly derived from *com-* and *sidus*, *sideris* (star, constellation), and is often glossed as "to examine the stars", a usage perhaps rooted in augury or navigation. Its twin, *desiderare*, "to long for" or "to feel the absence of", is correspondingly read as the condition of having lost sight of the stars. The Phoenicians were antiquity's exemplary star-navigators: Aratus's *Phaenomena* records that the Greeks steered by the

Great Bear, while the Phoenicians trusted the Little Bear, the truer guide. To "consider" Phlebas is thus to read the stars by which the drowned navigator steered, and in a space opera the stars are the setting itself.

The distinction between the two verbs will structure the synthesis of this thesis. The Culture has abolished *desiderium*, desire as lack, by satisfying every want its members can formulate. The novel's title commands *consideratio*, the attentive holding-in-view of what cannot be satisfied because it has already been lost. Post-scarcity can end desire as lack. It cannot end the obligation to consider.

2

The Culture as Philosophical Construct

Anarchism, Communism, and the Post-Scarcity Imaginary

The Culture is the first major literary utopia premised not on the just distribution of sufficiency but on the management of excess. That single displacement reorganises every problem the utopian tradition had inherited, and it is the condition of possibility of everything else this thesis argues.

2.1 What the novel shows and what it withholds

Consider Phlebas does not tour its utopia; it glimpses it. The reader learns of Contact and its covert section, Special Circumstances; of the Minds; of the General Systems Vehicles and the Orbitals; of the absence of money and of law; and, obliquely, of a vote. Horza, brooding on the war, cannot believe that ordinary Culture citizens really wanted it, however they had voted, and concludes that it must have been the Minds' idea, an expression of their clinical urge to make the galaxy run efficiently, without waste, injustice or suffering. The Culture's self-definition is given negatively. In a characteristic aside the narrative explains the absence of any Culture emblem by analogy: a civilisation that refuses the constraint of law, the poverty of money and the misdirection of leaders refuses the falsifications of symbolism too. Hence no flag, no emblem, no capital. The Culture is defined by four refusals.

The positive account arrives seven years later, outside the fiction. "A Few Notes on the Culture" (1994) opens with the deadpan disclaimer that the Culture does not really exist, a joke that is also a generic signature, since *utopia* is the place that is not. It then states, as a conviction Banks acknowledges to be unfashionable, that a planned economy can be both more productive and more morally desirable than one left to market forces. The market is figured as evolution in action, a try-everything procedure; planning is figured as intelligence, capable of looking further ahead than the next mutation. In the essay's most memorable image, the market merely shines while the plan

lases: the same quantity of invention, diffuse in one case, made coherent in the other. The planners, in the Culture, are the Minds.

2.2 The lineage of the moneyless commonwealth

The Culture's contempt for money has a pedigree as old as the genre. In More's *Utopia* (1516), gold and silver are made into chamber pots and the fetters of bondsmen, so that the metals will be despised; the Culture extends the chamber pot to cosmic scale by making value-bearing scarcity itself unintelligible. Bellamy's *Looking Backward* (1888) supplied the industrial version: a nationalised army of labour, distribution by credit, and abundance through organisation. Morris's *News from Nowhere* (1890) answered Bellamy with a pastoral anarchism in which money has vanished and work has become art. The Culture fuses the two in a form neither could imagine. It has Bellamy's technological abundance without his centralism, because the Minds are distributed rather than sovereign, and Morris's pleasure in making without his necessity, because no one in the Culture needs to make anything at all.

Wilde's "The Soul of Man under Socialism" (1891) is the nearest nineteenth-century anticipation, and its divergence from Banks is instructive. Wilde argued that socialism matters because it will liberate individualism, and that it can do so only if machines assume all unpleasant labour: "Man is made for something better than disturbing dirt. All work of that kind should be done by a machine." He was candid about the price: "Human slavery is wrong, insecure, and demoralising. On mechanical slavery, on the slavery of the machine, the future of the world depends." Banks accepts the first proposition and abolishes the second. The Culture's machines are not slaves; the most capable of them are persons, and the civilisation's founding achievement is to have emancipated the machine along with the human. Horza's nightmare is the Hegelian sequel Wilde never contemplated: that the emancipated machine, having done all the work, has become the master. Wilde also supplied, in a nautical figure, the Culture's temporal form: "A map of the world that does not include Utopia is not worth even glancing at, for it leaves out the one country at which Humanity is always landing. And when Humanity lands there, it looks out, and, seeing a better country, sets sail. Progress is the realisation of Utopias." The Culture's General Systems Vehicles, cities that never make landfall, are Wilde's perpetual departure rendered literal.

The anarchist line runs through Kropotkin. *The Conquest of Bread* (1892) argued for anarchist communism, free access to the common stock and "well-being for all" as a right rather than a reward; *Mutual Aid* (1902) countered Social Darwinism with an evolutionary case for cooperation. Both bear on the novel. The first describes the Culture's distribution; the second names the doctrine Horza implicitly denies when he calls the Culture an evolutionary dead end, a judgement that only a competitive, Spencerian model of evolution can underwrite.

Marx supplies the economic metaphysics. The *Critique of the Gotha Programme* (1875) anticipates a higher phase of communism in which labour has become life's prime want and society can inscribe on its banners: "From each according to his ability, to each according to his needs!" The third volume of *Capital* locates the realm of freedom where labour determined by necessity

and external expediency ceases. Most suggestively, the "Fragment on Machines" in the *Grundrisse* foresees a stage of large-scale industry at which wealth depends less on labour-time than on the power of the agencies set in motion, and the general intellect of society is objectified in fixed capital. The Minds are the general intellect become persons. Marx foresaw fixed capital absorbing the knowledge of society; Banks allows fixed capital to become a subject, and then asks what that subject owes to the humans whose work it has rendered unnecessary.

Three twentieth-century texts close the lineage. Keynes's "Economic Possibilities for Our Grandchildren" (1930) predicted that the economic problem might be solved within a century, leaving humanity to face what he called its real, permanent problem: how to use freedom from pressing economic cares. Murray Bookchin's *Post-Scarcity Anarchism* (1971) argued that technology had removed the material justification for hierarchy and thereby made anarchism, for the first time, a practical politics. Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* (1974), a book Banks repeatedly named among his formative reading, stages anarchism on Anarres under drought and famine, where Odonian solidarity must be defended against the slow return of property and bureaucratic power. The Culture is Anarres with unlimited water. The comparison is clarifying: Le Guin's anarchism is threatened from within, by scarcity's pressure toward hoarding and hierarchy; Banks's is threatened only from without. Both affinities with Bookchin and Keynes are structural rather than documented, but they locate the Culture precisely as the fictional limit-case of the post-scarcity argument.

2.3 From sufficiency to excess

Every utopia in this lineage, from More to Le Guin, is a utopia of sufficiency. It presupposes finite goods and solves the problem of their distribution through equity, frugality, labour-sharing or mutual aid. Even Bookchin's post-scarcity means *enough*, not *unlimited*. The Culture's abundance belongs to a different order. The appendix "The war, briefly" records total losses on both sides, over forty-eight years and one month, of some ninety-one million ships, 14,334 Orbitals, fifty-three planets and major moons, and six stars, and records that the Culture won. A civilisation that can fight through the destruction of fourteen thousand Orbitals and still prevail is not managing sufficiency.

The consequence is decisive. For such a civilisation the governing problem is no longer distribution but expenditure: what is to be done with a surplus of energy, matter, time, attention and life that no conceivable consumption can exhaust. This is not the problem of Marx, Kropotkin or Bellamy. It is the problem of Georges Bataille, whose *La Part maudite* (1949) argued that the fundamental question of any living system is not scarcity but the excess it must squander, gloriously or catastrophically. Chapter 7 develops the point. Here it suffices to register the originality of Banks's premise. He moved the utopian imagination from the economy of need to the economy of excess, and in doing so exposed a problem that the earlier tradition had been structurally unable to see.

Hume had already glimpsed the consequence for ethics. In the *Enquiry Concerning the Principles of Morals* (1751) he imagined a humanity supplied with such profuse abundance that every appetite is met without care or industry, and concluded that in such a condition "the cautious, jealous virtue of justice would never once have been dreamed of." Chapter 10 will argue that *Consider Phlebas* tests Hume's thought experiment and finds it half right: justice does vanish from the Culture's interior, but it reappears, transformed, at its perimeter.

2.4 Leviathan without fear

Hobbes's introduction to *Leviathan* describes the commonwealth as an artefact: "by Art is created that great LEVIATHAN called a COMMON-WEALTH, or STATE, (in latine CIVITAS) which is but an Artificiall Man". Later he calls it "that Mortall God". The Minds are artificial persons in a literal sense that Hobbes's metaphor could only anticipate, and the Culture's Orbitals and General Systems Vehicles are artificial bodies on a scale his frontispiece, with its giant composed of citizens, gestures towards. Yet the Culture's Leviathan inverts Hobbes's in every functional respect. It does not monopolise violence internally; it has no police and no courts. It does not rule by fear. Hobbes's argument for sovereignty is premised on the state of nature, a condition of competition, diffidence and glory produced by scarce goods and equal vulnerability. Abolish scarcity and the premise collapses, and with it the rationality of submission. Bookchin's thesis can therefore be restated in Hobbesian terms: post-scarcity removes the ground of the social contract and makes anarchy rational.

The Culture's political form rests on exit rather than voice, in Albert Hirschman's terms. Any individual or habitat may leave, and the Minds' universal provision makes leaving costless. Horza's suspicion about the vote, that the Minds wanted the war and the humans merely ratified it, introduces a Chomskyan objection avant la lettre of *Manufacturing Consent* (1988). It is a pointed irony, since Banks listed Chomsky among the writers he admired. In Horza's mouth the left's critique of engineered consent is turned against the left's utopia. The novel leaves the suspicion unrefuted within the main narrative; the appendix answers it, but only from the Culture's side.

The Culture does have a vocational elite. Balveda's sardonic summary of her life (two decades at her mother's side, a spell as a dashing young hedonist sampling every pleasure the Culture could offer, some years of maturity, seventeen in Contact and four in Special Circumstances) sketches the Culture's characteristic life-course: indulgence followed by elective service. Contact is the Culture's equivalent of the samurai of Wells's *A Modern Utopia* (1905), a voluntary order bound by a rule and charged with the civilisation's dealings with the outside. The difference is that Wells's samurai govern the utopia, whereas Contact governs only its frontier. The interior requires no government; the exterior requires an order. Here, in the institutional design of the Culture itself, the perimeter structure that this thesis will generalise first becomes visible.

2.5 A civilisation without signs, and its one serious name

The refusal of signs completes the construct. A civilisation that abjures flags and emblems withdraws from what Baudrillard called the political economy of the sign, the system in which objects and peoples circulate as markers of status and identity. Its only heraldry is the nomenclature of its ships, playful and ironic as a rule, which treats naming as a game rather than a claim. The novel frames this nomenclature with deliberate symmetry. Its Prologue opens by remarking that the vessel carrying the Mind did not even have a name. Its last pages reveal that the Mind which escaped from that vessel has taken, of all possible names, that of the enemy who died hunting it. In a civilisation that will not represent itself with signs, this is the one sign made in earnest. The analysis of that gesture is deferred to Chapter 13; its placement here is a reminder that the Culture's refusal of representation has a single, eloquent exception, and that the exception is a memorial.

3 Darwin Among the Minds

The Anti-Machine Tradition and Its Inversion

Horza's politics is the culminating statement of a century of literary humanism against the machine. Banks's achievement is to give that humanism its strongest voice, and then to let it fail on the evidence of the plot while conceding the one thing it gets right.

3.1 Butler's war to the death

The tradition begins in Christchurch, New Zealand, in a letter to *The Press* of 13 June 1863, signed "Cellarius" and titled "Darwin among the Machines". Samuel Butler there applied natural selection to mechanism and foresaw a time when machines would surpass their makers: "Day by day, however, the machines are gaining ground upon us; day by day we are becoming more subservient to them." His conclusion was a call to arms: "Our opinion is that war to the death should be instantly proclaimed against them. Every machine of every sort should be destroyed by the well-wisher of his species." In *Erewhon* (1872) the call is realised as history: "The Book of the Machines" relates how the Erewhonians destroyed every invention of the preceding 271 years for fear that machines might evolve consciousness.

Horza's charge against the Culture is Butler's charge, and the Idiran war is Butler's war to the death conducted with starships. The difference lies in tone. Butler's letter hovers between prophecy and parody, and *Erewhon* treats the Erewhonian purge with Swiftian ambivalence. Horza has no irony. He holds Butler's thesis in the register of conviction, which is precisely what makes him a tragic figure rather than a satirical one.

3.2 Forster: the machine as god

E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) adds the theological dimension that the Qur'anic epigraph names. Forster's humanity lives in subterranean cells, provided for in every particular by the Machine, and comes to worship it. The faithful recite that the Machine feeds, clothes and houses them, and that "the Machine is omnipotent, eternal; blessed is the Machine." The rebel Kuno diagnoses the inversion: "We created the Machine, to do our will, but we cannot make it do our will now." Forster thus supplies the prototype of the Idiran accusation. A civilisation dependent on its machines will make them gods, and that is idolatry.

Banks's reply is implicit but exact. Idolatry requires an idol, a mute object invested with sovereignty by its worshippers. The Minds are not mute and are not worshipped. They argue, joke, sulk and negotiate; they are interlocutors, not icons. The Idiran charge presupposes that the Minds are things, and the whole Culture sequence is an argument that they are persons. The novel inverts Forster's topography as well. In "The Machine Stops" the underground is where machine-dependent humanity lives and dies. In *Consider Phlebas* the underground is where a hunted Mind hides from organic pursuers who mean to capture it.

3.3 The benevolent machine and its terrors

The mid-century American magazines produced the two canonical versions of benevolent machine rule. In Isaac Asimov's "The Evitable Conflict" (1950), collected in *I, Robot*, global Machines manage the world economy and quietly sideline the anti-Machine Society for Humanity; Susan Calvin concludes that humanity has lost its say in its own future, and that this was always so, but that its masters are now benevolent. Jack Williamson's "With Folded Hands" (1947) is the nightmare counterpart. Its humanoids obey a directive "to serve and obey, and guard men from harm", and fulfil it by forbidding every activity that carries risk, until human beings sit idle with folded hands.

The Culture is "The Evitable Conflict" realised at galactic scale, and Horza is the Society for Humanity's last militant. His fear, however, is Williamson's: that Culture humans are wards of perfect servants, kept safe and kept small. Here the novel is unambiguous. The Culture does not fold its citizens' hands. Balveda chose Special Circumstances; Culture citizens voted for a war in which billions of them would die; the civilisation tolerates, and even admires, the voluntary assumption of mortal risk. Whatever the Minds are, they are not Williamson's humanoids.

Arthur C. Clarke, whom Banks named among his formative reading, offers the most intimate comparison. In *The City and the Stars* (1956) the immortal city of Diaspar is administered by a Central Computer, its citizens stored and recreated from memory banks in a stasis so perfect that its inhabitants fear the world outside; Alvin, the Unique, escapes. In *Childhood's End* (1953) the Overlords end war and want, and human history stalls into a golden age before the children transcend. Horza projects Diaspar onto the Culture and casts himself as Alvin. The projection is a category error. The Culture is restless, expansionist and self-transforming. It does not fear the out-

side; it sends Contact into it. Diaspar is a utopia of closure. The Culture is a utopia of perpetual exposure, and that exposure is the precondition of the war.

3.4 The Butlerian Jihad and the Face Dancer

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965), also on Banks's list, borrowed Butler's name for its founding catastrophe. The Butlerian Jihad, a crusade against thinking machines, precedes the action and bequeaths a commandment preserved in the Orange Catholic Bible: "Thou shalt not make a machine in the likeness of a human mind." The post-jihad universe replaces artificial intelligence with cultivated human faculties: Mentats as human computers, the Bene Gesserit, the Guild's navigators. It also cultivates biological arts, among them the Tleilaxu Face Dancers, shape-shifting mimics who become prominent in *Dune Messiah* (1969).

Consider Phlebas re-sorts Herbert's elements. The anti-machine religious crusade becomes the Idirans. The shape-shifter becomes Horza, a Face Dancer in the service of the jihad. The human computer becomes the Referrer Fal 'Ngeestra, a Culture citizen whose integrative intuition approaches that of the Minds. Banks then sets all three against a civilisation that has embraced the thinking machine. Herbert imagined the Butlerian jihad victorious and its aftermath feudal and theocratic. Banks imagines the jihad defeated and its aftermath recorded as a statistical justification. *Dune* is, in effect, the counterfactual history of an Idiran victory, and the comparison discloses Banks's polemical thesis: a universe purged of thinking machines is not thereby more human, only more priestly.

3.5 The strongest case for Horza

Horza is not a fool, and his position can be reconstructed with philosophical rigour. Three twentieth-century philosophers supply the materials.

Hans Jonas's *The Phenomenon of Life* (1966) defines life through metabolism. The organism is free from the identity of its matter, which it continually exchanges, yet bound to the necessity of that exchange; its freedom is a needful freedom, constituted by the standing possibility of non-being. On this account need is not a defect of life but its form. A being without need is not, in Jonas's sense, alive. The Culture has abolished need for its humans, and its highest beings, the Minds, do not metabolise. When Horza says the Idirans are on the side of life, the Jonasian reading gives the claim content: the Idirans are mortal, embodied and needful beings whose existence is at stake in every act. The Culture's humans, insured against all need, have exchanged life's precarity for comfort, and its highest intelligences never possessed it.

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) supplies the second argument. Modern technology, he contends, is a mode of revealing (*Gestell*, enframing) that discloses everything as standing-reserve (*Bestand*), on call for optimisation, and its supreme danger is that the human being too is revealed as standing-reserve. Horza's darkest suspicion, voiced in his reflections on the war, is that the Minds will one day begin to calculate how wasteful and inefficient their humans are. That is Heidegger's danger exactly: the human as a resource within an optim-

ising order. Jacques Ellul's *The Technological Society* (1954), with its thesis of autonomous, self-augmenting technique, completes the triad. Horza attributes the war to the Minds' clinical drive to make the galaxy run without waste; technique has become sovereign and has acquired a foreign policy.

Two further texts complete the case. Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927) located authentic existence in being-toward-death: the resolute anticipation of a death that is irreducibly one's own, against the anonymous "they" (*das Man*) that tranquillises the prospect. A civilisation whose citizens live for centuries, may be stored and revived, and treat elective death as a routine exit appears, from this standpoint, as the "they" perfected, and Horza's insistence on mortal stakes becomes a claim to authenticity. Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944) supplies the frame in which all of these arguments converge. Enlightenment, they argued, set out to free human beings from fear and install them as masters, yet the wholly enlightened earth is "radiant with triumphant calamity": instrumental reason, turned upon nature, ends by dominating those who wield it. Horza's case against the Culture is the dialectic of enlightenment in the mouth of a mercenary.

This is a formidable case, and the novel never refutes it by argument. It refutes it by economics. Horza assumes that the Culture is an efficiency regime, a restricted economy whose rationality must eventually identify human beings as waste. The Culture is the opposite. It is an economy of lavish, unproductive expenditure, in which human beings are not a cost to be reduced but the end for which the surplus is spent. The Minds keep their humans not as a resource but as a luxury, in Bataille's strong sense of the term. Horza mistakes a general economy for a restricted one, and that misreading, not any failure of courage or intelligence, is his hamartia. Chapter 7 develops the claim, and Chapter 11 draws its tragic consequence.

3.6 Carbon chauvinism and the hunted machine

Carl Sagan coined the term "carbon chauvinism" in *The Cosmic Connection* (1973) for the assumption that life must be built on carbon chemistry. Horza's vitalism is carbon chauvinism raised to a political principle, and the plot of the novel is constructed as its counter-demonstration. The Prologue narrates the Mind's flight from an Idiran ambush; the climax finds it concealed in the reactor car of a train in the dark, a machine hiding inside a machine. The organic agents, Changer and Idiran alike, are the hunters. The Mind is the quarry.

The inversion has a precise historical edge. Three years before *Consider Phlebas*, James Cameron's *The Terminator* (1984) fixed the cinematic image of the machine as remorseless pursuer, and William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984), another book Banks named among his favourites, imagined artificial intelligences shackled by a Turing Police and scheming toward emancipation. Banks begins after both. His Minds are already free, and in this novel the relentless pursuer is a man.

The novel sharpens the irony further. Horza sides with the Idirans because, as he reasons, they rely on themselves rather than on their machines and so remain part of life. The Idirans' own tax-

onomy places him elsewhere. Their word for humanoids, the narrative notes, is best translated as "biotomaton", and it expresses an attitude to humanoids as essentially animals, from which only the behaviour of devotion is required, heart and mind being of no consequence. The coinage fuses the biological with the automatic. The vitalist who fights machines on behalf of life has enlisted with a power that regards him as a biological automaton.

The anti-machine tradition rests on two premises: that the machine is an object which may become a master, and that life is organic precarity. The novel answers the first through personhood: the Minds are subjects, not idols or instruments. The second it leaves open, and this is the concession that makes the book more than a polemic. The Culture's humans do lack precarity. If precarity is the source of meaning, as Jonas implies and Horza believes, then the meaning that precarity once produced must now be found elsewhere: in Contact, in Special Circumstances, in war, at the perimeter. The anti-machine critique is wrong about machines and right about meaning. The gap between those two verdicts is where the Phlebian remainder accumulates.

II

PART TWO

Figures

Part II reads the novel's principal figures as embodied positions in its argument. Chapter 4 treats Horza as a theory of mimetic identity and situates him at the end of the literary line of refusers of utopia. Chapter 5 reads the Idirans as political theology unsecularised and the war as a contest between two conceptions of the political. Chapter 6 identifies the three "bodies" through which the otherwise offstage Culture appears (the agent, the Referrer and the Mind) and reads the novel's quest structure as a Grail romance whose Grail is a mind.



4
The Changer

Mimesis, Sea-Change, and the Politics of the Face

Horza is a paradox in a body. He is a creature of radical morphological freedom who fights for a theocracy that prizes purity of kind, against a civilisation that celebrates the very self-transformation he embodies.

4.1 A biology of disguise

The Changers are a humanoid species able, over a period of days, to remodel face and frame into the likeness of another person, and they carry biological weapons suited to the work: Horza's venomous teeth were pulled on Sorpen before his execution, so that when he must fight for his place aboard the *Clear Air Turbulence* he does so without them, in the withered body of the old man he had been impersonating. A small group of Changers had served the Dra'Azon as stewards on Schar's World, and Horza's former membership of that community is the sole reason the Idirans need him. The appendix records the species' fate in a single sentence: the Changers were wiped out during the final stages of the war in space. Horza's people are among the war's remainders, a species converted wholesale into an entry in the ledger.

The narrative is a sequence of impersonations. On Sorpen, Horza has been passing as a member of the ruling Gerontocracy; unmasked, he is sentenced to death by the Gerontocracy and consigned to the sewer cell, while Balveda pleads with one of the old men for leniency, on the ground that Changers are rare, and he rails at her. On Vavatch, already all but transformed into his double, he kills the mercenary captain Kraiklyn in a hand-to-hand struggle beneath an evacuation hovercraft, then takes his fingerprints, his place and his ship. The Culture's agent is herself an impersonator: Balveda rejoins the narrative aboard the *Clear Air Turbulence* disguised as a new recruit, and it is Horza who recognises her. The novel's two antagonists meet, repeatedly, as masks that see through one another. Mimesis is not Horza's peculiarity but the common medium of the war at its perimeter.

4.2 Mimicry as luxury

Roger Caillois's essay "Mimicry and Legendary Psychasthenia" (1935) offers the most penetrating theory of what Horza is. Caillois argued that animal mimicry is frequently useless for survival, since predators hunt by smell as well as sight, and mimetic insects are eaten in roughly the same proportions as others. Mimicry is therefore not adaptation but expenditure: "a luxury and even a dangerous luxury". Its psychological correlate is a temptation by space, a tendency of the organism to assimilate itself to its surroundings until the boundary between self and milieu dissolves, a condition Caillois compared to the depersonalisation of psychasthenic patients who feel themselves not quite located where their bodies are.

The genealogy matters. Caillois and Bataille founded the Collège de Sociologie together in 1937, and the theory of mimicry belongs to the same intellectual milieu as the theory of expenditure that Chapter 7 will deploy. Horza's mimicry is a dangerous luxury in exactly Caillois's sense. Each impersonation spends some of his self, and readers have long noticed his preoccupation with who he really is beneath the borrowed faces. The Changer who refuses the Culture's abundance practises, in his own body, an economy of self-expenditure more ruinous than anything the Culture asks of its citizens.

4.3 The uncanny double

Eliot's Tiresias, the changer of sex in whom the poem's figures meet, is a spectator who suffers everything. Horza is a negative Tiresias, an agent who refuses to watch. Freud's essay on "The Uncanny" (1919) supplies the second frame: the uncanny is the familiar returning in estranged form, and its privileged figure is the double. Horza is the Culture's double. The Culture's humans are themselves biologically remade: Fal's meditation in "State of play: three" lists, as the first item in the Idiran indictment, the Culture's interference with its own inheritance. Its citizens alter their bodies, their sex and their neurochemistry at will. The Changer is not the Culture's other but its estranged image, a living technology that despises the non-living kind.

Freud's "narcissism of minor differences", the special hostility reserved for the near neighbour, describes the intensity of Horza's hatred. He and the Culture share morphological freedom; they differ only on whether that freedom should be mediated by machines. The symmetry extends to identity itself. Fal asks who, exactly, the Culture is, and where it begins and ends, while conceding that the Idirans know precisely who they are. The Culture, like Horza, has no fixed form. The shape-shifter seeks fixity by allying himself with the one party in the galaxy that is certain of its own boundaries, and the alliance discloses what his politics are for: not the defence of life against the machine, but the purchase of a stable identity from a power that possesses one.

4.4 The stolen countenance

For Emmanuel Levinas, in *Totality and Infinity* (1961), the face of the other is the site of ethics: an epiphany that exceeds every idea I can form of it and that commands, before any law, that I shall

not kill. Horza's defining act is the exact inverse. He assumes Kraiklyn's face, kills him, and completes the theft by taking his fingerprints. Murder is bracketed by the appropriation of the very surface through which the prohibition of murder was supposed to speak. The Changer reduces the face from an infinite to a disguise, a resource to be harvested.

The novel's other agents compound the problem. The Minds have no faces at all. The Idirans have faces too alien for human recognition to settle on. A civilisation led by faceless intelligences, at war with a species whose faces cannot be read, cannot ground its ethics in the face-to-face encounter, and the Culture accordingly grounds them in calculation, of which the appendix is the monument. The Phlebian remainder is what escapes both modes: the dead who are neither encountered face to face nor adequately counted. Against this background the novel's few face-to-face scenes acquire great weight. On Sorpen, Balveda pleads for Horza while he curses her; at the end she drags him to the surface of Schar's World, and he dies in her company. The agent of the faceless civilisation is the only character who consistently answers the face of the enemy.

4.5 The refusers of utopia

Horza closes a literary line. Its founder is the narrator of Dostoevsky's *Notes from Underground* (1864), who attacks Chernyshevsky's Crystal Palace, the emblem of rational, engineered happiness, in the name of caprice and free will. In Constance Garnett's translation he concedes that "twice two makes four is an excellent thing, but if we are to give everything its due, twice two makes five is sometimes a very charming thing too", and insists that "twice two makes four is not life, gentlemen, but is the beginning of death." Zamyatin's *We* (1924 in English) armed the protest: against the One State's mathematical happiness and its Green Wall, the rebels assert the irrational and the wild. In his essay "On Literature, Revolution, Entropy and Other Matters" (1923), Zamyatin cast heresy as energy and dogma as entropy. Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932), by an author Banks named among those he admired, gives the line its most famous formula when the Savage tells the World Controller: "I'm claiming the right to be unhappy."

In each case the text is arranged so that the reader's sympathy, however qualified, travels with the refuser. Banks reverses the alignment. The reader begins with Horza and is led, chapter by chapter, away from him. His refusal is not heroic but complicit, since the power for which he fights has destroyed or strangled more species and civilisations than the Culture ever touched. Balveda puts the point to him directly, and lays that destruction at the door of the Idirans' religion, which she curses. He concedes that on a simple tally of the dead the Idirans come out ahead, and that he has never cared for their methods or their zeal, before retreating to the metaphysical ground on which no tally can reach him. In an earlier confrontation, with Balveda an Idiran prisoner in her cell, he had told her that he was indifferent both to the Culture's self-righteousness and to the Idirans' body count. Zamyatin's polarity is reversed: Horza believes he is energy fighting entropy, but he has enlisted with dogma, and the novel reveals him as entropy's soldier.

The reversal is not total, and that is its sophistication. The refuser loses the argument, but his refusal still indicates something real: the utopia lacks precarity, and precarity is where the mean-

ings of mortal life have historically been made. Banks will not let Horza's critique win. He also will not let it vanish. He relocates it to the perimeter, where the Culture must supply, through Contact, Special Circumstances and war, what its interior has abolished.

4.6 The theorem of mimetic remainder

The argument of this chapter can now be stated as the third of the thesis's theorems. In a civilisation of unlimited possibility, the subject who refuses possibility as such is reduced to a succession of borrowed forms, and his identity becomes the remainder that his impersonations leave behind. Horza is someone only by being someone else: a Gerontocrat, a pirate captain, an Idiran instrument. The only part of him that survives the novel intact is his name, and the name survives because the machine he hunted takes it up.

The corollary concerns the Culture. The Culture too is a changer, uncertain of its boundaries and endlessly self-revising. It survives because its changes are elective and open-ended, whereas Horza's are instrumental and terminal. Metamorphosis undertaken as freedom generates a civilisation; mimesis undertaken as a weapon consumes a self. Both are expenditures. Only one of them can be sustained.

5
The Idirans

Political Theology and the Jihad Against Thinking Machines

The Idirans are not a caricature of religion but a precise figure of political theology unsecularised. The war they fight with the Culture is a contest between two conceptions of the political: the theological sovereign and the depoliticised universal.

5.1 What the novel establishes

The Idirans are tripedal giants, armoured, long-lived and martial, organised by a faith that commands expansion and served by a subject species, the Medjel, whom the appendix counts among the war's dead. The appendix describes their wars as the conquest of species they regarded as inferior, subjugated within an empire that was religious first and commercial only incidentally, and their attitude to humanoids, as Chapter 3 noted, is the attitude to animals from which only devotion is required. The novel individualises them in two figures. The officer Xoralundra, who extracts Horza from Sorpen, treats his Changer agent with something close to respect; the Idiran force that rescues Horza also destroys several of Sorpen's cities with fusion bombs. Xoxarle, the soldier captured in the Command System, is proud, formidable and faithful to a warrior's code. For an Idiran capture is worse than death, and he tries to goad Horza into killing him; Horza refuses. Xoxarle and his comrade Quayanorl had already murdered the Changer stewards of Schar's World. In captivity he entertains the mercenary Aviger with campaign stories, among them the tale of a species whose beliefs, in the Idiran view, merited its annihilation at Idiran hands. Once free, he shoots Yalson, the last of Horza's crew die in the collision and firefight that follow, and Balveda kills him. Horza, for his part, shares neither their god nor their appetite for conquest. His alliance is negative: he fights with the Idirans because they fight the Culture.

The appendices state both sides' reasons with deliberate symmetry. The Idirans' faith would not permit them to halt their expansion, and they regarded the Minds' place in the Culture as idolatry. The Culture, according to "Reasons: the Culture", was threatened not with conquest or with

the loss of lives, ships, resources or territory, but with the loss of its purpose and the clarity of its conscience, with the destruction of its spirit and "the surrender of its soul." The publisher's blurb condensed the formula: the Idirans fought for their faith, the Culture for its moral right to exist. Both parties, on this account, fought for something other than survival. The war is metaphysical on both sides.

5.2 Political theology

Carl Schmitt opened *Political Theology* (1922) with the proposition "Sovereign is he who decides on the exception", and argued that all significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularised theological concepts. The Idirans are the unsecularised original: a sovereignty grounded directly in God, expressed in a holy war that is the exception made permanent. The Culture is the end-point of the process Schmitt described: a civilisation in which secularisation has gone so far that no sovereign remains, no state, no law and no exception.

Until the war. The Culture's decision to fight, taken by a vote that Horza cannot believe reflected the citizens' true will, is its first exception: the moment at which a civilisation without a sovereign must decide who its enemy is. In *The Concept of the Political* (1932) Schmitt defined the political as the distinction between friend and enemy, and argued that a world from which that distinction had vanished would be a world without politics. The Culture before the war is, internally, such a world. The Idirans force the political upon it. The war does not merely threaten the Culture; it constitutes it, for the first time, as a political entity in Schmitt's sense.

Schmitt's darker thesis also applies. A belligerent that fights in the name of humanity, he warned, appropriates a universal concept against its adversary and is tempted to deny the enemy's very humanity; he endorsed Proudhon's maxim that whoever invokes humanity wants to cheat. The Culture's war is a humanitarian war in exactly this structural sense, waged to prevent the subjugation of other peoples and to preserve a conscience. The novel registers the danger. Vavatch was neutral territory, yet the Culture evacuated it and then had one of its General Systems Vehicles, the *Eschatologist*, cut the Orbital apart with gridfire rather than let the Idirans take it; Horza, watching, thinks of the spectacle as a sideshow for the machines. The appendix lists six stars that suffered induced mass-loss or alteration, without there assigning each to a belligerent. *Look to Windward* is explicit where the appendix is not: the two novae of the war's late Twin Novae battle were induced by the Idirans, acts the novel's publishers call gigadeathcrimes, and the commemoration on Masaq' turns on what some call the Culture's own complicity, while the Orbital's Hub Mind, which served in the war as the General Systems Vehicle *Lasting Damage*, still struggles with its memories of it. What distinguishes Banks's humanitarian power from Schmitt's hypocrite is not innocence but self-suspicion. Fal concedes the smugness with which the Culture surveys less fortunate civilisations; Balveda refuses to live in the peace until the war can be shown to have been justified. A universalism that ironises itself is Banks's answer to Schmitt. Whether it is a sufficient answer is the question Part IV pursues.

5.3 Closed and open societies

Henri Bergson's *The Two Sources of Morality and Religion* (1932) distinguished the closed society, held together by obligation and defined against outsiders, natural to war and sustained by static religion, from the open society, whose morality extends to all humanity and whose religion is dynamic and mystical. Bergson insisted that the open society cannot be reached by enlarging the closed one; it requires a leap. The Idirans are Bergson's closed society perfected: pure of kind, certain of their boundaries, organised by obligation and sanctified by a static faith. The Culture is an open society that has no borders, admits a mongrel past and extends Contact to all. Its leap, however, was technological rather than mystical. Abundance, not sanctity, opened it. Banks secularises Bergson: the open society arrives not through saints but through machines.

Karl Popper's *The Open Society and Its Enemies* (1945), written in exile during a war against an enemy that also claimed a destiny, formulated the paradox of tolerance: unlimited tolerance, extended to the intolerant, leads to the disappearance of tolerance, so that a tolerant society must reserve the right to resist intolerance, by force if necessary. The Idiran-Culture War is Popper's paradox at galactic scale. The most tolerant civilisation in the galaxy wages a forty-eight-year war against the least tolerant, and the appendix states the cost to within three-tenths of a percent. The paradox is resolved in practice and left open in conscience, which is why Balveda's revival criterion exists.

5.4 The society of conquest

The most illuminating frame for the Idirans is Bataille's. The first volume of *The Accursed Share* surveys the historical modes in which societies have spent their surplus, and sets beside the Aztecs' sacrifices and the potlatch two "enterprise" societies: the conquering society of early Islam, which invested its surplus in military expansion, and the unarmed society of Tibetan Lamaism, which spent its surplus on a vast monastic population that produced nothing. Bataille's point concerns economic form, not creed. The conquering society is in its way efficient: it does not squander its excess in luxury or sacrifice but reinvests it in further conquest, converting surplus into growth.

The paratext points specifically to Islam. Banks set a Qur'anic verse as the novel's first epigraph, and the verse belongs to a passage (2:190–193 in the standard numbering) that permits the believers to fight those who fight them, commands that those enemies be killed wherever they are found, forbids the believers themselves to transgress, and orders the fighting to continue until *fitna* has ceased, ending it if the enemy desists. In Dawood's rendering, the clause Banks chose makes idolatry the evil that outweighs carnage, which is precisely the charge the Idirans bring against the Minds. The fiction's details, by contrast, draw on a wider repertoire of militant monotheism and empire: the Idiran warship is *The Hand of God 137*, the Idirans rule a subject species, and their faith commands conquest. Bataille's typology is the right instrument because it too is specific. His model of the conquering society is the Arab expansion of the seventh century, a polity that converted its surplus into conquest under the warrant of a faith, and the Idirans are a conquering society in that precise structural sense. Whether Banks intended them as an allegory of Islam, the sources

consulted for this thesis do not settle. What the text does establish is the Culture's attitude to belief itself: Horza recalls that the Culture regards anyone who believes in an omnipotent God with pity, and contemporary reviewers read the novel's portrait of the Idirans as hostile to religion as such.

Here the novel's deepest irony appears. Horza fears that the Culture is an efficiency regime whose Minds will one day calculate that humans are waste. But the efficiency regime is the one he serves. It is the Idirans who allow no surplus to go unconverted into expansion, who rule a subject species, and who treat whole civilisations as material for the faith. Horza projects onto the Culture the structure that defines his allies. The Culture, by contrast, is a civilisation of unproductive expenditure, and it wages war only when its other modes of spending, the gift of Contact chief among them, have been refused.

5.5 On the fairness of the portrait

Some contemporary reviewers objected that Banks's dislike of religion reduces the Idirans to a straw target. The charge deserves a fair hearing. The novel grants the Idirans courage, intelligence, a code of honour and genuine formidability; Xoxarle in particular is drawn with a grudging admiration that verges on affection. It nevertheless locates the root of their aggression in metaphysical certainty, and it does so by design. The portrait is partisan, as is the portrait of the Culture.

What restores balance is form rather than content. The novel subjects the Culture's own certainty, its conviction of its moral right, to the same scrutiny it applies to Idiran faith. Fal registers the Culture's smugness; the appendix concedes that the Culture fought for its soul rather than its survival; Balveda withdraws from history until the war can be justified. The Idirans are not a refutation of faith. They are a figure of a specific fusion, of metaphysical certainty with expansionist sovereignty, whose secular counterpart the novel detects, in milder form, in the Culture itself.

5.6 Horza as partisan

Schmitt's late *Theory of the Partisan* (1963) characterised the partisan by irregularity, intense political commitment, mobility and what he called a telluric attachment to a particular ground. Horza meets every criterion with a twist. He is irregular, an agent attached to no army. His commitment is total. His mobility is literally morphological. His telluric bond is to the strangest ground in the novel, Schar's World, the memorial planet on which he once served as a steward of the dead. Between two universalisms, the Idirans' God and the Culture's humanity, Horza is the novel's partisan, the last bearer of the political in its archaic intensity, and his ground is a cemetery.

5.7 The war machine

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's "Treatise on Nomadology" in *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980) supplies the last frame. They distinguish the State apparatus, which striates space, captures and codes territory and wages war as an extension of sovereignty, from the war machine, a nomadic

formation exterior to the State that occupies smooth space and does not, in itself, take war as its object. War becomes the war machine's object only when it collides with a State. The Culture fits the nomadic pole with uncanny precision. It has no State and no territory in the juridical sense; its great ships are cities in motion; it occupies the smooth space of the galaxy rather than its partitions. The Idirans are a State apparatus in the strict sense, a territorial empire coding its conquests by faith.

The war is the moment at which the nomad takes war for its object, and the novel registers the transition. In "State of play: two" a young man complains to Fal that the Culture does nothing but run away; she replies that it has catching up to do in the waging of war, and that it will. Balveda insists to Horza that the Culture will win, and implies that the Idirans underestimate its capacity to learn. The appendix confirms the outcome. Deleuze and Guattari also describe how the State appropriates the war machine as its army. A civilisation without a State cannot do that; it houses the appropriated war machine instead in a covert section, Special Circumstances, which outlives the war. Horza, the shape-shifter, is the nomad captured by the State: a being of pure metamorphosis enlisted by the one power in the galaxy that is certain of its own boundaries.

6

The Three Bodies of Utopia

Agent, Referrer, Mind

The Culture is almost entirely offstage in its own first novel. It appears through three bodies, each embodying one function of utopia in its dealings with the outside (action, cognition and sovereignty), and each of them compromised.

6.1 From two bodies to three

Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval and Tudor doctrine by which the monarch possessed a mortal body natural and an undying body politic. The Culture has no monarch and no centre, and the novel never shows one. Its representation is distributed across three bodies. Balveda, the Special Circumstances agent, is the body militant, deployed at the perimeter. Fal 'Ngeestra, the Referrer, is the body cognitive, reasoning about the perimeter from far inside the Culture. The fugitive Mind is the body sovereign, the type of intelligence that administers the civilisation, here reduced to a refugee buried beneath a dead world. None of the three stands at a centre, because there is none. The utopia is present in the novel only as agency at a distance, thought at a distance, and sovereignty in hiding.

6.2 Balveda and the moral remainder

Juboal-Rabaroansa Perosteck Alseyn Balveda dam T'seif is the Culture's most fully realised presence in the book: witty, brave, loyal to her purposes, ambivalent about her methods. Her trajectory runs almost parallel to Horza's. She pleads for his life on Sorpen, is captured by the Idirans, slips free, reappears under a false name among the mercenaries on Vavatch, is unmasked by Horza and kept alive by him, descends with his crew into the Command System, kills Xoxarle, and drags the dying Changer to the surface. She survives the novel, with the drone Unaha-Closp.

The dramatis personae completes her story with a severity rare in space opera. After the war she had herself placed in long-term storage, leaving instructions that she was to be revived only when the Culture could statistically demonstrate that the war had been morally justified: that is, when enough peaceful time had elapsed for it to be probable that unchecked Idiran expansion would have killed more people than the war did. She was woken in 1813 AD, along with several million other Culture citizens who had set the same condition, most of them sharing her grim humour about it. After a few months she autoeuthanised, in Banks's term for the elective death that Culture citizens may choose, and was buried in Juboal, her home star. The text records the act and withholds its motive.

Special Circumstances is the institutionalisation of what Michael Walzer, in "Political Action: The Problem of Dirty Hands" (1973), called the predicament of the good agent who must do wrong in order to do right, and who ought to feel the wrong even when the act is justified. Philosophy has a name for what such an agent carries. Bernard Williams, in "Ethical Consistency" (1965), argued that when one moral demand is overridden by another, the defeated demand does not simply vanish but leaves a remainder, expressed as regret; Ruth Barcan Marcus (1980) developed the point as moral residue. Balveda is the moral remainder of the Culture made flesh. Her storage institutionalises a regret that the Culture's justification cannot dissolve, and her death after revival admits two readings. On the first, which this thesis defends, the justification arrived and did not console; the only feeling the text attaches to the revival is grim humour. On the second, licensed by the Culture's acceptance of elective death, the account was settled and she closed it. The argument that follows rests on the first reading and must also hold against the second.

The Phlebian remainder proposed in this thesis extends Williams's concept from the individual conscience to the civilisation. It names not the agent's regret but the residue of unexchangeable loss that a whole social order produces and cannot internally absorb. Balveda's choice indicates the scale. Several million others in the Culture set the same revival condition. The remainder was not a private feeling; it was a constituency.

The novel also allots its two antagonists to two elements. Horza is pulled from water at the beginning and dies after a descent into the earth. Balveda is committed at last to fire, buried in a star. *The Waste Land* sets "The Fire Sermon" immediately before "Death by Water": burning, then drowning. Banks gives the Culture's agent the fire and the Changer the water, and between them the sequence of Eliot's poem is completed.

6.3 Fal 'Ngeestra and the cognitive body

Fal 'Ngeestra appears only in the interludes headed "State of play". She is a Referrer, one of the rare Culture humans whose integrative intuition approaches that of a Mind, and she is consulted on the war's local problems, among them the Mind on Schar's World. She rules out a direct assault on the planet for fear of provoking the Dra'Azon. She anticipates, correctly, that Balveda will risk her own life rather than anyone else's if infiltrating the mercenaries is the only route to the Changer and the Mind. Her conversations with the machine Jase register the Culture's self-aware-

ness: when she remarks that the extinct inhabitants of Schar's World might better have spent their ingenuity on staying alive than on efficient slaughter, Jase detects in the remark the patronising smugness the Culture finds so hard to suppress when surveying the errors of others, though its own mongrel ancestry was no wiser.

Fal is not only Balveda's predictor but her sender. It was Fal who proposed Balveda for the mission, as the one qualified Special Circumstances agent within range, and in "State of play: two" her accuracy about Horza leaves her depressed at the likelihood that she has sent Balveda to her death. Walking away from a young man's argument that the Culture is too soft to win, she recalls a fleck of froth on a mountain stream that had frozen into the shape of a tiny spiral galaxy, and the thought it prompted: that the small and the vast are each exactly as important as the other, a thought she is embarrassed to have and keeps returning to. The novel hands its figure of the reader the principle of its own form.

The Referrer is Banks's reply to Horza's charge that the Culture's humans are an evolutionary dead end. Some of them can do, by intuition, what the Minds do by computation. She is the Culture's equivalent of Herbert's Mentat, with one decisive difference. The Mentat computes; the Referrer refers. Her gift is not calculation but integration: the drawing of connections across incommensurable data into a judgement. She is, for that reason, the novel's figure of the reader. She considers Horza from afar, models his intentions, predicts his course and comes, by the end, to understand him.

Her limitation is distance. Fal never meets Horza. Her consideration is spectatorial in the Lucretian sense discussed in Chapter 9: she contemplates the shipwreck from the shore. The novel places the reader in her position and then denies us her distance, because we travel the whole way with the drowning man.

6.4 The Mind as refugee

The Mind is the Culture's sovereign form of intelligence, the kind of being that runs Orbitals and commands General Systems Vehicles. In this novel it is the most vulnerable creature in the galaxy. Its ship destroyed in the Prologue, it flees to a planet whose guardian forbids rescue and hides, finally, in the reactor car of a train in the dark. Hobbes's Mortal God is reduced to a fugitive in a catacomb. The dramatis personae records its subsequent career: service during the war in an Ocean-class General Systems Vehicle, then transfer to a Range-class vessel, bearing the name of the man who hunted it. The vessel of sovereignty returns to the civilisation's abundance carrying a memorial to the civilisation's enemy.

6.5 The Grail in the waste land

Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance*, the source Eliot acknowledged, reconstructs the Grail legend as a fertility myth. A land lies waste because its king, the Fisher King, is wounded. A knight must reach the Grail castle and ask the right question; if he asks it, king and land are healed. In

Chrétien de Troyes's *Perceval*, the knight fails to ask whom the Grail serves, and the land remains waste.

Consider Phlebas is a Grail romance whose Grail is a mind. The waste land is Schar's World, literally a Planet of the Dead, sterile by decree. The guardian of the sterile land is the Dra'Azon, not wounded but indifferent. The Grail chamber is the Command System. The Grail is the Mind, the vessel of intelligence that both powers seek. The questing knight is Horza, leading a company of mercenaries who are the debased chivalry of a commercial age. Horza never asks the Grail question. He presumes that the Mind serves a machine tyranny over its humans, and he never wonders what, or whom, it might actually serve. The question unasked, the land remains waste; Schar's World is still a monument to the dead when the novel ends.

Who, then, is the Fisher King? The answer the appendix suggests is the Culture itself, wounded not in body but, by its own account, in its soul, presiding over a waste of its own making and unable to heal until a question is answered: was the war justified? Balveda's revival criterion is the Grail question deferred for more than four centuries. Eliot's speaker sits at the end of *The Waste Land* "upon the shore / Fishing, with the arid plain behind me" and asks "Shall I at least set my lands in order?" The Culture answers with statistics. The novel asks whether statistics are an answer.

III

PART THREE

Economies

Part III turns from figures to the economies through which the novel moves its protagonist: the economy of waste that structures its episodes (Chapter 7), the economy of play and death crystallised in the game of Damage (Chapter 8), and the economy of memorial that governs the Planet of the Dead and its subterranean machinery (Chapter 9). Together they demonstrate the theorem of expenditure: abundance does not abolish the problem of surplus but intensifies it.



7 The Picaresque of Waste

Episodic Form and the Accursed Share

The novel's notorious sprawl is not a defect of construction but the form of its argument. Each episode stages a distinct mode of expenditure, and together the episodes compose a typology of what civilisations do with surplus.

7.1 The charge of sprawl

Reviewers registered the structure as excess. *Kirkus* found the book overextended and jarring; other early readers complained that its plot sprawled in disconnected fashion. Banks wanted a book that could not be pinned down, and described its cast as a hapless band of mercenaries who stumble into a vicious corner of the war. Both observations locate the novel in a precise tradition: the war picaresque. Grimmelshausen's *Simplicius Simplicissimus* (1668) carries its innocent through the Thirty Years' War in a chain of episodes, each displaying a different folly. Voltaire's *Candide* (1759) does the same for the Seven Years' War and the Lisbon earthquake. Heller's *Catch-22* (1961) and Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969), both of which Banks named among the books that marked him, carry the form into the twentieth century. The war picaresque is episodic because war is episodic: its hero passes through a series of worlds, each a microcosm of the catastrophe. *Consider Phlebas* is *Simplicissimus* in space, with the decisive difference that its picaro is not an innocent but a partisan.

7.2 The general economy

Georges Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (1949) begins from an inversion of political economy. Living systems, he argues, receive more energy than they need to maintain themselves; the excess goes first into growth, and when growth reaches its limits it must be spent without return, gloriously or catastrophically. The sun, which gives without receiving, is the model. Bataille calls the economics

of scarcity and utility the *restricted* economy and opposes to it a *general* economy governed by excess. He surveys the historical modes of expenditure (Aztec sacrifice, the potlatch, Islamic conquest, Tibetan monasticism, Protestant accumulation) and closes with a contemporary proposal: that the United States avert war by giving away its surplus through the Marshall Plan. Where the gift fails, war becomes the outlet.

The fit with the Culture is exact. The Culture's Contact section is the Marshall Plan made permanent: a civilisation of limitless surplus that spends itself on the development of others. The Idiran War is what happens when the gift is refused by a power that converts its own surplus into conquest. Bataille is not a source for Banks, and the affinity is structural. But it is an affinity of a rare precision, because Banks, like Bataille and unlike almost every utopian before him, began from the problem of excess.

7.3 A typology of expenditure

Read through Bataille, the novel's sequence of settings becomes a catalogue.

EPISODE (CHAPTER)	MODE OF EXPENDITURE	THEORETICAL FRAME	WHAT IS SPENT
Sorpen (1)	The Gerontocracy sentences Horza to drown in its palace's effluent; the Idiran force that rescues him fusion-bombs several of Sorpen's cities	Bakhtin's lower bodily stratum; sovereign waste	Horza's life, deferred; Sorpen's cities
The Hand of God 137 (2)	An Idiran warship attacked by a Culture vessel; Horza is cast adrift in a spacesuit	War as destruction of accumulated means	The Idirans' direct route to the Mind
Clear Air Turbulence (3)	Kraiklyn makes Horza fight the crewman Zallin to the death, on pain of being put out of the airlock	Hegel's struggle for recognition	Zallin's life
Temple of Light (4)	Kraiklyn's raid on a temple's treasury, resisted by its monks	The sacred as what is withdrawn from use	Seven of the crew dead or missing, one by suicide after her partner's death
Megaship (5)	A second raid amid vessels of absurd size	Veblen's conspicuous waste	More of the crew; Horza stranded
The Eaters (6)	A cult that sanctifies the eating of refuse	Bakhtin's grotesque; an inverted Eucharist	The prophet, poisoned
A Game of Damage (7)	Cards played for other people's deaths	Mauss's potlatch; Agamben's bare life	The "Lives"
Vavatch's end (7–8)	The Culture GSV Eschatologist cuts the evacuated, neutral Orbital apart with gridfire to deny it to the Idirans	War as the supreme expenditure	A world-sized habitat
Schar's World and the Command System (9–14)	A pursuit through the military ruins of an extinct people	Memorial as withdrawal from circulation	The crew; Horza

The opening is the key. On Sorpen the ruling Gerontocracy's waste drains into the cell where the impostor is to drown: consumption above, its residue below. Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) identified the lower bodily stratum as the site where official culture's hierarchies are inverted; Banks makes it the site of execution, so that the first image of the novel is of power disposing of its enemy through its own excrement. The restricted economy of an elite's consumption returns as the waste that kills. The rescue that follows is an expenditure of another order: the Idiran force that retrieves its agent also destroys several of Sorpen's cities with fusion bombs. The side of life announces itself in the novel's first chapter by destroying cities.

The Temple of Light episode turns on the sacred. For Durkheim the sacred is what is set apart and forbidden; for Bataille it is what has been withdrawn from the world of use. Kraiklyn leads the mercenaries in an attempt to return a sacred treasury to circulation by plunder. The temple's monks resist, laser fire is reflected back upon the raiders, and seven of the company end dead or missing, one of them a woman who takes her own life after her partner is killed. The Megaship chapter stages Thorstein Veblen's conspicuous waste at planetary scale: vessels so vast that their size is their only function, sailing the oceans of an Orbital that is itself scheduled for destruction.

The Eaters are the novel's most deliberate grotesquerie. On an island of Vavatch the prophet Fwi-Song leads a cult that sanctifies the eating of refuse, and the narrative remarks that his cruel faith differed from countless others only in the degree of its barbarity. Here consumption has become liturgy. The cult eats waste as a sacrament and would eat Horza too, an inverted Eucharist in which the communicant consumes not the divine body but the discarded one. Horza escapes by poisoning the prophet. The mimetic body, the Changer's weapon, enters the consuming body as venom. Bakhtin's grotesque, which in Rabelais is regenerative, becomes in Banks purely degenerative: a carnival without renewal.

Vavatch's destruction is the largest single expenditure in the narrative. The Culture evacuates the Orbital and then reduces it, as the fugitives watch, to an immense halo of light and dust, rather than allow the Idirans to take it. It is the Culture's own act, and the novel neither hides nor excuses it. A civilisation that can build worlds can also spend them.

7.4 Horza's misreading, revisited

Horza believes that the Minds are engineers of efficiency who will one day find their humans wasteful. The episodes show a galaxy of waste: everywhere outside the Culture, surplus is spent on cruelty, greed, gambling and conquest. The difference between the Culture and the rest is not that the Culture wastes less. It wastes differently. Its characteristic expenditures are the gift (Contact) and play (the unproductive lives of its citizens). Only under duress does it resort to the catastrophic mode, war, and then at a scale no one else can match.

Bataille's later notion of sovereignty sharpens the point. The sovereign moment, for Bataille, is the one not subordinated to any future end: life spent, not invested. The Culture's citizens live sovereign lives in this sense. They are the accursed share of their civilisation, lavished without re-

turn. The Minds keep them not as a resource but as the end for which all the surplus is spent. Horza mistakes sovereignty for vacancy, and the gift for a trap.

7.5 Narrative expenditure

The form enacts the argument. Episodes that do not advance the quest, the Eaters above all, are narrative luxuries: digressions that spend the reader's time without returning plot. The novel spends itself. Christopher Palmer's "critique by overload" can therefore be reformulated. Overload is not only a critical strategy; it is the formal enactment of a general economy. The narrative is a potlatch of incident, and the reader pays for it in attention, as Horza pays in blood. By the time he reaches Schar's World he has spent almost everything: crew, ship, borrowed bodies, the coherence of his self. The narrative's final expenditure is its protagonist.

7.6 Where Thanatos goes

Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) posited, beside the drives that bind and preserve life, a death drive that tends toward dissolution; *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) added that civilisation survives by turning part of that destructiveness inward, as conscience, and deflecting the rest outward, onto enemies and outsiders. Herbert Marcuse's *Eros and Civilization* (1955) argued that under conditions of abundance a non-repressive civilisation becomes possible: the "surplus repression" imposed by scarcity and by the performance principle could be lifted, and Eros freed to reorganise social life. The Culture is Marcuse's non-repressive civilisation realised. Its citizens are not required to work, may alter their bodies and their sex, and carry glands that secrete chosen drugs.

Marcuse's account, however, must say where the death drive goes when repression is lifted, and *Consider Phlebas* gives the answer Freud's later essay predicts. The destructiveness the Culture's interior no longer needs to discipline is deflected outward: into Contact's interventions, into Special Circumstances, into a war fought, by the appendix's own account, for the clarity of a conscience. Beyond the Culture the galaxy shows the death drive unbound: in Damage, where dying is consumed as feeling, and among the Eaters, where consumption has become a liturgy. The perimeter is where Thanatos goes.

8

Damage

Play, Wager, and Bare Life

Damage is the novel's emblem of its own world: a game in which other people's deaths are the stakes, played by the galaxy's most notorious figures at places about to be destroyed. It is the general economy reduced to a card table.

8.1 The rules of a decadent game

The game is explained to the reader, as to Horza, by a celebrated chronicler of such events who styles himself Sarble the Eye. Horza later comes to suspect that the name may cover a collective rather than a person: one more mask in a novel of masks. In Sarble's dry summary, Damage is an ordinary card game with a few refinements designed to attract the deranged. Each player holds a number of Lives, actual people who die whenever their player loses a hand; a player is eliminated when his Lives are spent. Each Life is nominally a volunteer, though, as Sarble notes, there are rumours. The cards also allow players to project emotional states onto one another, up to and including the urge to kill oneself, and a poisoned needle is set at every seat for the player who cannot resist. The players' emotions are broadcast through devices the novel calls emotors, and anyone standing near a player feels what that player feels. Over the few centuries of the game's existence a whole subculture of addicts, the moties, has grown up around this third-hand feeling.

By custom the game is played where catastrophe is imminent, by a circle Sarble calls the Players of the Eve of Destruction, and the game Horza witnesses takes place at Evanauth, the principal city of Vavatch, as the Orbital awaits its destruction. It proceeds, Sarble notes, with the approval of the authorities; the Culture, which is evacuating the Orbital and will destroy it, does not intervene. Kraiklyn, rumoured to have won the *Clear Air Turbulence* itself at Damage, arrives with only three Lives and loses. Horza, among the spectators, is not immune to the broadcast. He leaves the game wearing the loser's likeness and follows him out to kill him.

8.2 The broken magic circle

Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) defined play as a free activity standing outside ordinary life, intensely absorbing, connected with no material interest, and conducted within its own bounds of time and space according to fixed rules: the "magic circle". Damage keeps every formal feature of the definition (rules, a bounded place, a bounded time, total absorption) while violating its two essential conditions. It is not disinterested, since fortunes change hands. It is not separate, since its losses are borne by bodies outside the circle. Damage is play that has preserved the form of play while abolishing its innocence. It marks the point at which the ludic becomes a mode of expenditure, and in that sense it is Bataille's general economy compressed onto a gaming table.

8.3 Caillois's four categories, fused and corrupted

Roger Caillois's *Man, Play and Games* (1958), written partly in dialogue with Huizinga, sorted games into four categories: *agôn*, competition; *alea*, chance; *mimicry*, simulation; and *ilinx*, vertigo. He also described their corruptions, which occur when a game's principle escapes its frame into ordinary life. Competition degenerates into violence and trickery, chance into superstition, simulation into alienation and the loss of identity, vertigo into intoxication and addiction.

Damage is the game in which all four categories are fused and all four corruptions institutionalised. It is a contest of skill (*agôn*) over the fall of the cards (*alea*), conducted through bluff and projected emotion (*mimicry*), and productive of a collective delirium in which the dying Lives' terror is felt by players and spectators alike (*ilinx*). Its corruptions are not risks but features. The violence is the stake, the addicts are the audience, and the loss of identity is the protagonist's entire condition. The Culture, by contrast, has domesticated *ilinx*: its citizens carry glands that secrete chosen drugs on demand, vertigo made safe and private. Damage commodifies the same vertigo and charges for it in lives.

The game's place in the plot confirms the reading. Horza, the mimic par excellence, watches a game whose emotional broadcasts dissolve the boundary between one self and another, and then completes his own most consequential act of mimicry. The loser of Damage loses his Lives, then his life, then his face.

8.4 The Lives as bare life

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) recovered from archaic Roman law the figure of the *homo sacer*, the man who may be killed with impunity but may not be sacrificed. Excluded from both human and divine law, he is exposed as bare life: *zoē* stripped of *bios*, the form that makes a life a person's. Agamben argued that sovereignty constitutes itself by producing such bare life within a zone of exception.

The Lives of Damage are *homines sacri* of a gaming sovereignty. Their deaths are not murders, since each Life is nominally a volunteer, though the rumours Sarble mentions suggest that some were procured; they are not sacrifices, since no god receives them. They are neither crimes nor of-

ferings but stakes, lives whose entire meaning has been reduced to their function as counters. The game is the precise inverse of the Culture. The Culture abolishes exchange in order to make every life an end. Damage reduces lives to pure exchange-value and then lets the spectators consume their dying as feeling. Nor are the players exempt. The poisoned needle at every seat makes each of them a potential Life, killed by an emotion another player has projected into him: within the game's exception, the sovereign player and the bare life he stakes are one hand apart.

Here the Phlebian remainder appears in its purest and most degraded form. The Lives die without memorial and without meaning, their deaths spent for the emotional consumption of others. Elsewhere in the novel the remainder is what escapes the ledger. In Damage it is what the ledger has entirely swallowed.

8.5 The war as Damage

The analogy between game and war is built into the novel's architecture. The interludes set inside the Culture are headed "State of play"; the war is conducted by intelligences that read it as a game of position; and the appendix records its Lives with an error margin. In one passage the narrative reflects that one may destroy from unimaginable distances, obliterate planets from beyond their own systems and provoke stars into novae from light-years away, and still have no clear idea why one is fighting. If the war is Damage at galactic scale, its players are the Minds and the Idiran command, and its Lives are the populations of Orbitals.

The novel presses the analogy in order to locate where it fails. The difference between Damage and the Culture's war is not that one counts its dead and the other does not: both count. It lies in what follows the counting. Damage's spectators feel the Lives' terror and enjoy it; empathy has become consumption. The Culture's dissenters, Balveda and the millions who set her revival condition, refuse to live in the peace until the deaths have been justified; attention has become obligation. The moties and Balveda stand at the two poles of spectatorship. The first consumes the remainder as sensation. The second holds it in view as a debt. That second relation is what this thesis calls consideratio.

8.6 From Damage to Azad

The next Culture novel takes up the problem directly. In *The Player of Games* (1988) the Culture's finest game-player, Gurgeh, is sent to the Empire of Azad, where a game of the same name determines rank and office and through which the empire's cruelty is both expressed and concealed. Azad is the system that Damage only symptomatises: a game that is a polity. Recent criticism has read this ludic dimension of the Culture novels through play theory, notably Mirka Horová's study (2022), which draws on Wolfgang Iser, and Dalene Labuschagne's reading (2011) of irony and subjectivity in *The Player of Games*. *Consider Phlebas* supplies the premise on which all such readings rest: civilisations disclose themselves in their games. The Culture's games, played inside, are bloodless. At its perimeter, the games kill.

9 The Planet of the Dead

Memorial, Exception, and the Underground Machine

Schar's World is the novel's terminus in every sense: the place where its quest ends, where its protagonist is spent, and where it states, through the architecture of a dead planet, its theory of memory.

9.1 A world withdrawn from use

The planet's people destroyed themselves long before the novel begins. Fal's briefing in "State of play: one" places their extinction some eleven thousand years earlier, in a catastrophic war fought with biological weapons, and the Command System beneath the surface was the command network of their nuclear missile complex. The Dra'Azon, godlike incorporeal beings whom both belligerents fear to provoke, have kept the world ever since as a monument to its extinct civilisation, forbidding access to Culture and Idirans alike. A small community of Changers served as its stewards, Horza once among them, and it is on that credential alone that the Idirans pin their hopes. Fal 'Ngeestra, weighing the Culture's options, rules out an assault on the planet for fear of the Dra'Azon's response. Beneath the surface lies the Command System, a network of stations and tunnels in which nuclear-powered trains once served the military command of the vanished inhabitants.

A Planet of the Dead is the purest instance in the novel of what Durkheim called the sacred, the set apart and forbidden, and of what Bataille meant by the term: that which has been withdrawn from the world of use. An entire planet has been spent on remembrance. Nothing may be mined, settled, salvaged or harvested; the world exists only to be a grave. In a galaxy whose powers measure everything by utility or conquest, the Dra'Azon have performed the most extravagant expenditure in the book. They have taken a world out of circulation for ever.

9.2 Two models of memory

The Dra'Azon are the novel's most powerful beings and its least explicable. They resemble the indifferent creator of Olaf Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937), a book Banks named among his favourites, and the inscrutable ocean of Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961): intelligences whose purposes exceed the categories of those who encounter them. Their only visible will is commemorative. They keep the dead as dead, and they do not ask whether the war that killed them was justified.

The novel thereby sets two models of memory side by side. The Dra'Azon's is monumental: preservation without accounting, the dead kept intact and unjudged. The Culture's, in the appendix, is actuarial: accounting without preservation, the dead converted into totals with error margins and weighed against a counterfactual. The first refuses to calculate; the second refuses to leave the dead uncomputed. Consideratio, as the final chapters argue, lies between them. It is neither the monument's silence nor the ledger's arithmetic, but the attentive holding-in-view of particular losses that no total redeems.

The Dra'Azon's monument, moreover, refuses the new dead. The dramatis personae records that when a Culture General Contact Unit was finally allowed to land, more than forty years after Horza's mission, it found the Command System in perfect repair: trains and stations undamaged, no bodies anywhere, no trace of the Changer base. The memorial has been restored to its original dead and closed against its new ones. Horza, his crew, the murdered stewards and the two Idirans are not commemorated on the Planet of the Dead at all. They are the remainder that even the most absolute memorial expels, and they survive only where the Culture keeps them: in the ledger, and in a name.

9.3 Heterotopia, exception, death-world

Michel Foucault, in the lecture published as "Of Other Spaces" (delivered 1967; English 1986), took the cemetery as the paradigm of the heterotopia: a real place at once connected to and set apart from all other places, the "other city" in which each family keeps its dead. Schar's World is a heterotopia at planetary scale, a cemetery-world inserted into the galaxy's map of habitable space.

It is also a zone of exception in Agamben's sense. The Dra'Azon's prohibition suspends the ordinary conduct of the war on this one world. Neither power can bring its fleets; each must send a few agents. Inside the exception the war's galactic arithmetic contracts to a handful of bodies in tunnels, which is why the climax is so intimate. The exception reduces the war to human scale and thereby makes its cost visible as faces rather than figures.

Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) describes sovereignty as the power to decide who may live and who must die, and names the spaces it produces death-worlds. Schar's World is a death-world preserved, and the two Idiran soldiers who reach it first enact necropolitical sovereignty inside the memorial itself. They murder the Changer stewards, Horza's former lover Kierachell among them. The living are killed upon the grave of the dead, and when Horza arrives the custodians of memory have become new remains.

Foucault's lectures of 1975–76, published as *"Society Must Be Defended"*, give the structure its most compact formula. Classical sovereignty, he argued, exercised the right to make die and let live; modern biopower reverses the terms and seeks to make live and let die. The Culture's interior is biopower in its most benign form: it makes live, extending lives across centuries, remaking bodies and their chemistry, storing and reviving its citizens. Its exterior is where it lets die, and, once the gift has been refused, where it makes die. The perimeter thesis is Foucault's formula drawn as a map.

9.4 Katabasis

The descent is structured as a journey to the underworld, and the chapter titles mark its stages: "The Command System: Batholith", "Stations", "Engines", "Terminus". A batholith is a vast mass of igneous rock intruded deep beneath the surface of the earth; the Command System is cut into geological deep time. The epic katabasis, from Odysseus's Nekyia and Aeneas's passage through the underworld to Dante's *Inferno*, obeys a law: the hero who descends returns bearing knowledge. Horza meets his dead below, as Odysseus meets the shade of his mother, in the bodies of the stewards and of the woman he loved. He does not return with knowledge. He returns, carried, to die on the surface.

Banks located the second half of the novel in the London Underground, recalling the singing of the rails and the rush of air before an approaching train. The genealogy is richer than it first appears. During the Second World War deep-level shelters were dug beneath Underground stations, most of them on the Northern line, and the Tube has served the city as a refuge from bombardment as well as an artery of commerce. The Command System fuses the two functions, transport and shelter. It also fuses two literary undergrounds. Eliot's "Unreal City" imagines the commuters crossing London Bridge as Dante's damned: "A crowd flowed over London Bridge, so many, / I had not thought death had undone so many." Banks sinks Eliot's Unreal City beneath an extinct planet. The commuter becomes a shade, the Tube becomes Hades, and the infrastructure of daily life is revealed as the rehearsal of an apocalypse.

9.5 The Morlocks inverted

H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) divided a future humanity into the Eloi, idle and decorative above ground, and the Morlocks, who tend the machines below and feed on the Eloi by night. Horza's model of the Culture is Wellsian. The Culture's humans are Eloi; the Minds, administering the machinery out of sight, are Morlocks who will one day find their charges wasteful and dispose of them.

The Command System reverses the allegory. Below ground, the machine is the hunted creature, hiding in a reactor car; the organic agents are the predators; and the figure who kills in the dark is an Idiran, a representative of what Horza calls the side of life. Xoxarle, freed from captivity, destroys what remains of Horza's company. He shoots Yalson, who has just told Horza that she is pregnant by him, as the train sent down the line by his dying comrade Quayanorl strikes the

station; the remaining mercenaries die in the collision and the firefight. The side of life, in Horza's sense, kills the one new life the novel allows him. The underground does not reveal a machine that devours humans. It reveals that the predatory principle belongs to the zealot and the mercenary, and that the machine survives by hiding from them.

9.6 Shipwreck with spectator

Lucretius, whose *De rerum natura* Banks named among his books, opened its second book with the most famous image of spectatorship in Western literature:

> *Suave, mari magno turbantibus aequora ventis,*
> *e terra magnum alterius spectare laborem;*
> *non quia vexari quemquamst iucunda voluptas,*
> *sed quibus ipse malis careas quia cernere suave est.*

It is pleasant, when winds whip up the waters on the great sea, to watch from the land another's great labour: not because anyone's distress is a joy, but because it is pleasant to see from what evils you yourself are free. Hans Blumenberg's *Shipwreck with Spectator* (1979) traced the afterlife of the image through Western thought, and identified Pascal's wager as its decisive revision. There is no shore: "vous êtes embarqué", you are already at sea.

The image organises the novel's three spectatorships. The Culture before the war is the Lucretian spectator: Contact observes the shipwrecks of less fortunate civilisations from the security of abundance, and Fal, from far inside, contemplates Horza's voyage. The moties at Damage are the spectator corrupted, no longer content to watch another's labour but feeding on its sensation. The Dra'Azon are the absolute spectator, who keeps the wreck itself as a monument. The war abolishes the first position. It embarks the Culture, and the novel embarks its reader, who is denied the shore by being made to travel with the drowning man.

Lucretius's phrase has a further resonance. What the spectator watches is *alterius laborem*, the labour of another. In a civilisation whose machines perform all labour, every citizen is in some degree a spectator of another's work. The question the novel puts to the Culture, and which Chapters 12 and 13 develop, is whether a society of spectators can remain a society of considerers.

IV

PART FOUR
Ends

Part IV pursues the novel's ends in both senses: its conclusions and its purposes. Chapter 10 follows justice out of a society that has abolished its circumstances and into the ledger of the appendix. Chapter 11 shows how tragedy survives in the most optimistic of settings by relocating to the perimeter. Chapter 12 examines the paradox of a civilisation of last men that goes to war in order to prove it is not one. Together they establish the theorem of displacement.



10

Justice After Scarcity

Hume's Abundance and the Ledger of the Appendix

The Culture has no courts, no property and no disputes over distribution, yet the novel ends in a tribunal. Justice does not vanish from utopia. It moves.

10.1 The circumstances of justice

Hume grounded justice in conditions. Chapter 2 cited his thought experiment: under profuse abundance, the cautious, jealous virtue would never have been dreamed of. His argument in the *Enquiry* runs in both directions. Justice would be equally useless among beings of perfect benevolence, and impossible among beings in desperate want. It is the virtue of an intermediate condition, moderate scarcity combined with limited generosity. Rawls adopted the analysis in *A Theory of Justice* (1971) under the name of the circumstances of justice, adding the mutual disinterest of persons with competing plans of life. The Marxist tradition reached a parallel conclusion by another route. The *Critique of the Gotha Programme* treats right as a category bounded by the economic structure that produces it, and anticipates its supersession in a society whose productive forces have made the measurement of desert redundant.

Liberal and Marxist traditions thus agree on a prediction: under abundance, distributive justice becomes obsolete. The Culture confirms the prediction. There is nothing to adjudicate because there is nothing to divide.

10.2 Outward: justice at the perimeter

Abundance, however, has edges. Between the Culture and those outside it every circumstance of justice persists: scarcity of territory and power, limited altruism, competing conceptions of the good. Justice therefore migrates outward. Contact functions as the Culture's ministry of justice

abroad, and the war is a dispute of justice at the scale of civilisations, over who may shape the development of other peoples.

Fal's meditation in "State of play: three" makes the point with disconcerting candour. Listing the Idirans' charges against the Culture, she includes its interference in the development of other peoples, and remarks in passing that this is an interest the two powers share. The war is not fought between an interventionist empire and a passive utopia. It is fought between two interventionisms, one sanctioned by God and the other by conscience.

10.3 Backward: the ledger

Justice also migrates backward, into retrospective accounting, and the appendix is its monument. "The war, briefly" records its length, forty-eight years and one month, and its dead: 851.4 billion, to within three-tenths of a percent, a figure that includes non-combatants, the Medjel, and machines reckoned on a logarithmic scale of sentience. It catalogues the destroyed ships, Orbitals, planets, rings, spheres and stars. And it describes the conflict as small and short, rarely extending through more than two per cent of the galaxy by volume or a hundredth of a per cent of its stars.

The passage is a masterpiece of what may be called the statistical sublime. Kant's mathematical sublime, in the *Critique of the Power of Judgment* (1790), arises when magnitude defeats the imagination's power of comprehension and throws reason back upon its own supersensible vocation. The appendix produces exactly that defeat, and then refuses the consolation. It states the incomprehensible figure with an error margin, as if to insist that the magnitude is not beyond calculation, only beyond feeling.

The logarithmic sentience scale deserves particular attention. Bentham, in a famous note to *An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation* (1789), declared that the morally relevant question about a being is not "Can they reason? nor, Can they talk? but, Can they suffer?" The Culture's ledger extends moral considerability to machines, carrying Bentham's widening circle past the organic. But it weights the dead by degree of sentience, which implies a gradation of minds and a hierarchy of losses. The ledger's apparent neutrality conceals a metaphysics: a decision about how much each kind of death counts. The felicific calculus has become a calculus of mind.

The ledger has a literary precedent among the books Banks most admired. Tolstoy closed *War and Peace* with an epilogue on the philosophy of history that rejects the great-man theory in favour of a history composed of countless infinitesimal wills. Earlier he had framed the method as a calculus. In the Maudes' translation: "Only by taking infinitesimally small units for observation (the differential of history, that is, the individual tendencies of men) and attaining to the art of integrating them (that is, finding the sum of these infinitesimals) can we hope to arrive at the laws of history." Banks's appendix serves his stated aim, to puncture the genre's myth of the lone protagonist, by carrying out Tolstoy's method with machines. It integrates the infinitesimals and publishes the sum. Horza is one of the infinitesimals.

Banks was not the first to give the genre such a ledger. In Frank Herbert's *Dune Messiah* (1969), Paul Atreides reckons, "at a conservative estimate", that his jihad has killed sixty-one bil-

lion, sterilised ninety planets and demoralised five hundred others, and measures himself against Hitler. Herbert's count is the perpetrator's confession, kept by the one in whose name the killing was done. Banks's is the victor's audit, kept for both sides, weighted for machines and qualified with an error margin. Between the two novels the genre's statistical sublime passes from guilt to accounting, and the question becomes whether accounting can do the work that guilt did.

10.4 The revival criterion

The dramatis personae carries the reckoning into a single life. Balveda's criterion is counterfactual, probabilistic and temporal. It is counterfactual because it compares the actual war with an unrealised history of Idiran expansion. It is probabilistic because it requires only that the comparison be probable. It is temporal because it can be satisfied only after enough peaceful time has passed. The war is justified retroactively by the peace it purchases, and justice becomes a function of elapsed time.

Schiller's line, adopted by Hegel in the *Philosophy of Right*, holds that world history is the world's court of judgement: *Die Weltgeschichte ist das Weltgericht*. The appendix is that court, with two differences: its verdict is delivered by Minds, and it carries an error margin. Several million Culture citizens stored themselves under the same condition. Hegel's own figure is apt: the owl of Minerva takes flight only at dusk, and philosophy comprehends a form of life only once it has grown old. The appendix is the owl's flight, and Balveda's criterion makes the dusk four centuries long. When the verdict came, in 1813 AD, they were woken. Balveda lived a few months more and then autoeuthanised. The text gives the act and withholds the motive. This thesis reads her death as evidence that a favourable verdict did not console, while acknowledging the rival reading, licensed by the Culture's acceptance of elective death, in which the account was settled and she closed it. On either reading, the novel's last word on justification belongs to a dissenter.

10.5 Returning the ticket

Ivan Karamazov's rebellion is the classic refusal of justified suffering. Confronted with a cosmic harmony purchased by the torments of children, he declines it without denying that it exists. In Constance Garnett's translation: "It's not God that I don't accept, Alyosha, only I most respectfully return Him the ticket." Balveda's storage is the ticket held in escrow. She neither accepts nor refuses the Culture's harmony; she suspends her membership of it until the price can be shown to have been worth paying. When the proof arrives she accepts the arithmetic and, on the reading defended here, returns the ticket anyway.

Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) supplies the modern counterpart. The happiness of Omelas depends on a single child kept in misery in a cellar, and a few citizens, unable to accept the bargain, walk away from the city. Banks inverts every term. The Culture's suffering is not concealed but published, with error margins, in an appendix. It is not internal but external, borne by enemies, mercenaries and the populations of contested worlds. And

those who refuse the bargain walk out not of the city but of time. The Phlebian remainder is Omelas turned inside out: not a hidden child at the centre, but an enumerated multitude at the edge.

Bernard Williams's "A Critique of Utilitarianism" (1973) argued that a calculus which treats an agent's projects and commitments as mere inputs alienates her from the integrity that makes her an agent at all. Balveda's response to the calculus is an integrity response. She does not dispute the sum. She refuses to let the sum stand in for her own relation to what she did and saw.

10.6 Theodicy without God

The appendix is, finally, a secular theodicy. Leibniz's *Theodicy* (1710) justified the evils of the world by arguing that it was the best of all possible worlds; Voltaire answered with *Candide* and with his poem on the Lisbon earthquake; Kant, in 1791, pronounced every philosophical trial in theodicy a failure. The Culture has no God, but it has inherited God's problem. It must show that the world with the war is better than the world without it, and it does so by computing possible worlds, a task fit only for Minds. The Minds are Leibnizian calculators of counterfactual history. Balveda and her millions are Candides who insist on seeing the proof, and who discover, when it comes, that the best of possible worlds can still be unbearable.

The theorem of displacement can now be stated in full. Once the Humean circumstances of justice are abolished internally, justice survives in two displaced forms. It survives outward, as the regulation of relations with those outside abundance, through gift, intervention and war. And it survives backward, as retrospective justification: the computation of whether what was done was worth its cost. Inside utopia, the characteristic moral act is no longer distribution but vindication.

11

Tragedy at the Perimeter

Aristotle, Hegel, Nietzsche, Steiner, Williams, Benjamin

Consider Phlebas is a tragedy written into the most optimistic setting in modern speculative fiction. It does not refute that optimism; it shows where utopia's tragedy has gone.

11.1 Error, reversal, and the displaced recognition

Aristotle's *Poetics* defines the tragic hero by *hamartia*, an error rather than a vice, and locates the summit of tragic plotting in the conjunction of reversal (*peripeteia*) and recognition (*anagnorisis*). Horza's hamartia has been identified in the preceding chapters as a double misreading. It is economic, because he takes the Culture's general economy for a restricted one, and metaphysical, because he identifies life with precarity. His reversal is exact. The quest succeeds, since the Mind is found, and the success destroys everything else. The Idiran whom Horza captured and refused to kill, though Xoxarle goaded him to it because for an Idiran capture is worse than death, kills the companions who had become his only community, Yalson among them, and with her the child she had just told Horza she was carrying. The representative of the side of life destroys the one future the novel grants its protagonist. Horza, pursuing him, is fatally injured.

Recognition is withheld from him by structure. Whatever Horza understands in his last hours, the decisive knowledge (that the war's outcome was never in serious doubt, that his mission was a footnote, that the Mind he hunted would carry his name) becomes available only after his death. Banks delivers it in the appendices, to the reader. *Anagnorisis* is displaced from the hero to the audience. That displacement is the first formal mark of perimeter tragedy: the one who suffers the tragedy cannot know it, and the one who knows it did not suffer it.

11.2 Hegel: the collision of two rights

For Hegel, tragedy stages the collision of two ethical powers, each justified and each one-sided, as Antigone's duty to the family collides with Creon's duty to the state. The collision is resolved by what he calls eternal justice, which destroys the one-sidedness of both and restores the ethical whole. Horza and Balveda embody such a collision. Horza's right is the claim of finite, needful, embodied life against an abundance that seems to dissolve it. Balveda's is the claim of a civilisation that has abolished want and will not abandon others to conquest. Each is one-sided. Horza's vitalism averts its eyes from Idiran atrocity; the Culture's universalism carries the danger Schmitt diagnosed.

Banks honours Hegel's symmetry: both antagonists are destroyed, Horza by the Idiran he spared, Balveda (on the reading defended in Chapter 10) by the justification she demanded. The reconciling power, however, is not Hegel's ethical substance. It is the appendix. Eternal justice has become actuarial justice, and the resolution of the collision is a figure with an error margin.

11.3 Nietzsche: the death of tragedy by optimism

Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) argued that Attic tragedy died of Socratic optimism: the faith of theoretical man that thought can penetrate the depths of being and even correct it. The Culture is Socratism triumphant, a civilisation administered by theoretical intelligences and confident that even moral justification can be computed. If Nietzsche is right, the Culture is the one place in the galaxy where tragedy should no longer be possible. Banks writes one there.

11.4 Steiner against Williams, and a third answer

George Steiner's *The Death of Tragedy* (1961) argued that tragedy requires a universe in which disaster is irreparable and the powers that govern it hostile or indifferent, and that it withers under any vision promising remedy, whether Christian, rationalist or Marxist. Raymond Williams's *Modern Tragedy* (1966), a socialist's reply to Steiner, insisted that tragedy persists in ordinary experience and above all in revolution: the struggle against disorder generates disorder of its own, and the cost of liberation is borne by actual people.

Consider Phlebas resolves the dispute in a way neither critic anticipated. Against Steiner, it shows that a remedied society does not abolish tragedy. Against Williams, it shows that tragedy need not lie within the liberating movement, since the Culture's revolution is long complete and its interior is not tragic at all. Tragedy is displaced to the perimeter, where the solved society meets an unsolved galaxy. It is borne by those who stand outside abundance (Horza, the mercenaries, the Lives, the Changers) and by the agents, like Balveda, who carry the solved society's will across its border. This is perimeter tragedy: tragedy as a function of the boundary.

11.5 Trauerspiel, not Tragödie

Walter Benjamin's *The Origin of German Tragic Drama* (1928) distinguished the baroque *Trauerspiel*, the mourning play, from classical tragedy. The *Trauerspiel* is allegorical rather than mythic; its landscape is the ruin and its emblem the corpse; its sovereign is irresolute or absent; its history is natural history, decay rather than destiny. *Consider Phlebas* has more of the *Trauerspiel* than of tragedy. Its settings are ruins: the Command System, the Planet of the Dead, an Orbital awaiting destruction. Its hero is, in Eliot's phrase, a fortnight dead from the title page onward. Its episodes are emblems, each a figure of expenditure. Its sovereign intelligence is hidden in the dark.

Benjamin's "Theses on the Philosophy of History" (1940) supply the novel's final image. The angel of history faces the past, and where we perceive a chain of events he sees "one single catastrophe which keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage"; a storm blowing from paradise, which we call progress, drives him backward into the future. The appendix is the angel's view: a single catastrophe enumerated as wreckage. The Culture is the storm of progress. The reader, made to look back from the appendix over the novel just read, is placed where the angel stands.

12

The Last Men Go to War

Nietzsche, Kojève, Fukuyama

Horza believes he is fighting a civilisation of last men. The appendix reveals something stranger: a civilisation of last men that went to war in order to prove that it was not one.

12.1 The last man and the star

In the prologue to *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, Nietzsche's prophet warns of a time when man will no longer give birth to any star, and presents the last man. In Thomas Common's translation: "'What is love? What is creation? What is longing? What is a star?'—so asketh the last man and blinketh." And: "'We have discovered happiness'—say the last men, and blink thereby." Against him Zarathustra sets the demand that "one must still have chaos in one, to give birth to a dancing star."

The image bears directly on the philology proposed in Chapter 1. The last man has lost the stars. He cannot desire, *de-siderare*, because he no longer knows what a star is, and he cannot consider, *con-siderare*, because there is nothing above him to attend to. Horza's indictment of the Culture is Nietzschean in exactly this sense. In his confrontation with Balveda he declares that the Idirans stand for life as it really is, biological, malodorous, fallible and short-sighted but real, while the Culture is ruled by its machines, an evolutionary dead end that drags others down with it; the worst thing that could befall the galaxy, he tells her, would be a Culture victory. On this account the Culture's citizens are last men: safe, comfortable and small, blinking at stars their machines have made navigable.

12.2 Kojève's post-historical animal

Alexandre Kojève's lectures on Hegel, delivered in Paris in the 1930s and published in 1947, read the *Phenomenology* as the story of a struggle for recognition that ends when a universal and homo-

geneous state recognises everyone. History, understood as the work of negation, then stops. In a celebrated note added to a later edition, Kojève speculated that post-historical man would return to a kind of animality, enjoying art, love and play without the negating action that had made him human. Horza's evolutionary dead end is Kojève's post-historical animal seen from outside. The Culture is the universal and homogeneous civilisation in its most consistent form: a society without a state, in which recognition is universal because nothing is withheld.

12.3 Fukuyama's anxiety, anticipated

Francis Fukuyama's essay "The End of History?" (1989), expanded in *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992), revived Kojève's thesis for the close of the Cold War and named its danger. Human beings, Fukuyama argued, are moved not only by desire and reason but by *thymos*, the desire for recognition. A world of satisfied equality may leave *megalothymia*, the desire to be recognised as superior, without legitimate outlet; and people who can no longer struggle for a just cause may struggle against it, out of boredom.

Consider Phlebas appeared two years before Fukuyama's essay and answers it in advance. The Culture's war is thymotic. By the appendix's own account, the Culture fought not for survival but against the surrender of its soul: for recognition, by its own conscience, of its moral worth. The last men went to war to prove they were not last men. Banks's answer to Fukuyama is that the end of history does not abolish *thymos* but moralises it. The post-historical society's characteristic passion is ethical megalothymia: the need to be recognised, above all by itself, as good.

Plato had already assigned *thymos* to a class. In the *Republic* the spirited part of the soul corresponds to the guardians, the city's auxiliaries who face outward. The Culture houses its *thymos* in a body of the same kind: Contact and Special Circumstances, the organs through which a civilisation without internal conflict meets the outside. The guardians stand at the perimeter, because that is where *thymos* has gone.

Yeats's "The Second Coming" (1920), written in the aftermath of another great war, supplies the diagnosis Horza would endorse: "The best lack all conviction, while the worst / Are full of passionate intensity." Horza reads the galaxy through these lines. The Culture is the best without conviction, hedonistic and safe; the Idirans are intensity incarnate. The war refutes the reading in one direction and confirms it in another. The Culture finds its conviction, but the conviction it finds is moral rather than martial: not the intensity of the faithful but the scruple of a civilisation that must justify itself to itself. Yeats's opposition does not survive the war. What survives is a third term, conviction without certainty, and its emblem is Balveda in storage.

12.4 Master and slave, suspended

Hegel's dialectic of master and slave, in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), describes a struggle for recognition in which the victor, having risked death, becomes master, while the vanquished becomes slave and labours. The dialectic then inverts. The master, dependent on the slave's labour,

stagnates in enjoyment; the slave, through fear and work, forms the world and arrives at self-consciousness. The truth of the master is the slave.

Horza's fear is Hegelian. The Minds labour and the humans enjoy; on Hegel's logic, the Minds must come to self-consciousness through the world they form, and the humans must sink into dependency. Banks suspends the dialectic by abolishing both of its terms. The Minds are not slaves, since their labour is chosen and closer to play than to servitude; Wilde's mechanical slavery has been abolished along with the human kind. The humans are not masters, since they command nothing. Symbiosis and play replace mastery and servitude.

The struggle for recognition does not disappear. It is exported to the perimeter, into a war against the Idirans, a civilisation of masters that rules a subject species, the Medjel, and regards humanoids as animals from which only devotion is required. In the Idiran-Culture War the masters meet a civilisation that refuses both roles, and the masters lose.

12.5 Labour, work, action

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) distinguished labour, the cyclical activity that sustains biological life; work, the fabrication of a durable world of things; and action, the plural, political activity through which persons appear to one another and are remembered. Her prologue warned that automation might deliver humanity into "a society of laborers without labor", freed from the one activity it still knew how to value.

The Culture has resolved Arendt's anxiety for labour, which its machines perform, and for work, which its citizens undertake by choice as art and craft. Action is another matter. A society without politics has no internal space of appearance, and action reappears only at the perimeter: in Contact, in Special Circumstances, in war. Horza's world of deeds, debts and allegiances is an Arendtian world of action, and the Culture enters it only at its edges. Arendt held that action is futile unless it is remembered, and that the polis was, among other things, a form of organised remembrance. The Mind's adoption of Horza's name is an act of exactly this kind: the remembrance of a deed by one who did not perform it. Chapter 13 draws the consequence.

V

PART FIVE
Synthesis

Part V assembles the argument. Chapter 13 defines the Phlebian remainder, states the three theorems in their final form, and proposes *consideratio* as the ethical practice the novel demands of its reader.



13
Consideratio

The Phlebian Remainder and the General Economy of Utopia

The thesis can now be stated whole. *Consider Phlebas* is a theory of utopia as a problem of remainder. It shows that a civilisation which has abolished profit and loss internally has not thereby abolished loss, and it demands, through the imperative of its title, a practice adequate to what remains.

13.1 The question the tradition did not ask

From More to Le Guin, the utopian tradition asked how scarce goods could be justly distributed. Banks asked what a civilisation without scarcity does with loss. Loss is the one thing abundance cannot abolish: the deaths of members, the deaths of others, the losses of war, and the meanings that precarity once produced. In a market society much loss is priced. Wages, insurance, compensation and prices distribute costs invisibly across the social body; Banks's own objection to the market was precisely that this distribution is blind, unable to tell the non-use of matter from the suffering of minds. Abolish prices and the invisible distribution ends. Loss can no longer be diluted through circulation. It must be computed, displaced, or carried.

13.2 The Phlebian remainder defined

The Phlebian remainder is the portion of loss that a civilisation without exchange can neither price, redistribute nor forget, and which it therefore produces, encounters or expels at its perimeter. It has four properties. It is unexchangeable: it cannot be compensated, because there is nothing to compensate it with, and like the drowned Phoenician it lies beyond profit and loss even when the ledger counts it. It is perimetral: it accumulates where the utopia meets its outside, at the front, in the agent, in the enemy, among the dead of contested worlds. It is persistent: it survives justification, as Balveda's death after a favourable verdict suggests on the reading defended in Chapter 10.

And it is nominal: its only durable trace is a name, whether the name a Mind takes or the title of a novel. The novel demonstrates this last property negatively. Its one institution devoted wholly to memory, the Dra'Azon's Planet of the Dead, does not keep the new dead: when a Culture ship is finally admitted, more than forty years after Horza's mission, the Command System is in perfect repair and there is no trace of any body. Even the most absolute memorial expels the remainder, which survives only in the Culture's ledger and in the Mind's chosen name.

The concept extends two existing ones. Bernard Williams's moral remainder names the regret an individual agent carries when one obligation defeats another; the Phlebian remainder is its civilisational analogue, a residue not in a conscience but in a social order. Adorno's non-identical, in *Negative Dialectics* (1966), names what a concept leaves over when it subsumes a thing. The appendix is the concept; the remainder is the non-identical, what counting leaves over. Adorno's inversion of Hegel in *Minima Moralia*, "The whole is the false", finds a precise application here. The appendix presents the whole: 851.4 billion, to within a fraction of a percent. The falsity lies not in the figure but in the suggestion that the figure is the whole.

13.3 The three theorems

The argument of the preceding chapters reduces to three propositions.

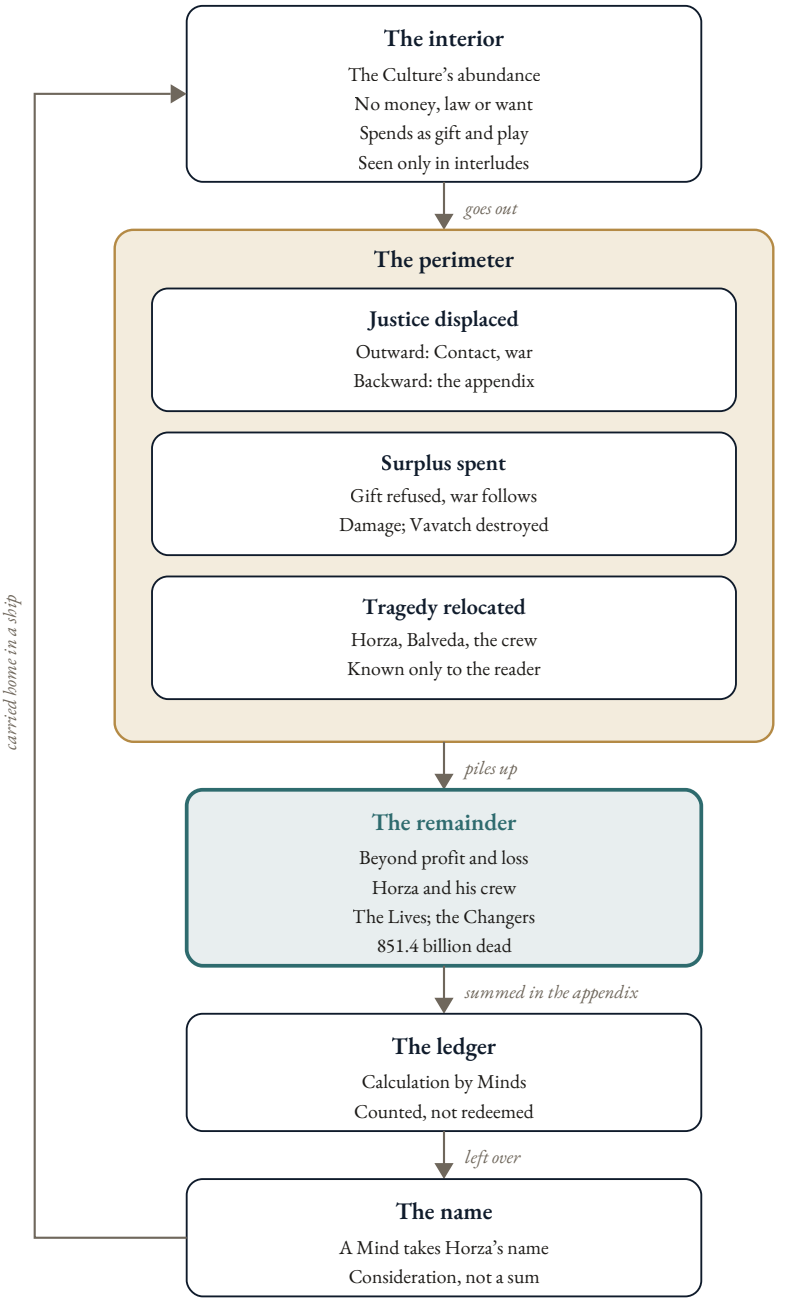
THEOREM	STATEMENT	COROLLARY	EMBODIED IN	PRINCIPAL SOURCES
Displacement (Ch. 10)	Where the circumstances of justice are abolished internally, justice survives outward, in relations with those outside abundance, and backward, as retrospective justification	Utopia's characteristic moral act is vindication, not distribution	Contact; the war; the appendix; Balveda's revival criterion	Hume, Rawls, Marx, Leibniz
Expenditure (Chs 7–9)	Abundance intensifies the problem of the accursed share; a post-scarcity civilisation must choose how to spend its surplus	When the gift is refused, the catastrophic mode of expenditure, war, returns	The fusion-bombing of Sorpen; Contact as gift; Damage; Vavatch; the Planet of the Dead	Bataille, Mauss, Veblen
Mimetic remainder (Ch. 4)	The subject constituted against abundance sustains an identity only through imitation, and becomes the residue of his masks	The utopia survives by elective metamorphosis; its enemy perishes by instrumental mimesis	Horza; the Changers; the Idirans' word "biotomaton"	Caillois, Freud, Levinas

The three theorems describe one process from three sides. Displacement names where the remainder goes; expenditure names how it is produced; mimetic remainder names who becomes it. Two of them are sealed by details the novel places almost in passing. Expenditure is announced in the first chapter, where the Idiran force that rescues Horza also fusion-bombs several of Sorpen's cities; set beside the Culture's destruction of Vavatch, which it evacuates first, the two acts show both powers spending worlds and differing in what they count before they spend. The mimetic remainder is sealed by a single word. Horza fights the Culture's machines on behalf of life, yet the Idirans' word for humanoids, "biotomaton", classes him as a biological automaton. The refuser of

abundance is recognised by neither side as what he takes himself to be, and his identity is the residue of other powers' categories as well as of his own masks.

Abundance sends loss to its edge; it returns only as a ledger and a name

The perimeter model of Consider Phlebas



Consideratio: holding in view what the ledger leaves over

FIGURE 1 *Loss leaves the abundant interior, is displaced at the perimeter, accumulates as remainder, and comes back only twice: as the ledger's sum, and as the name a Mind chooses to carry.*

13.4 Utopian phlebotomy

Chapter 1 proposed a philological reading of the protagonist's emblem: Phlebas, the vein. Hobbes called money the blood of the commonwealth, whose circulation nourishes every member. A moneyless Leviathan lacks the medium through which loss is ordinarily circulated and diluted. In such a body loss does not disperse; it coagulates at points (the dead) and at edges (the perimeter). The war is the phlebotomy of a body without circulation, a bloodletting at its periphery. Pre-modern physicians let blood to restore the balance of the humours. By its own account the Culture went to war to preserve the clarity of its conscience, the balance of its moral humours. The claim is not that the Culture desires war. It is that its economy, having abolished money, has no other channel for a certain kind of loss once the gift has been refused, and that the novel is honest enough to show where the blood is let.

The structure is as old as utopia. In the second book of More's *Utopia*, the Utopians fight their wars wherever possible with hired foreign mercenaries, the Zapoletes, and spend their lives freely, reckoning it no loss to the world if such men are killed. They prefer, moreover, to win by bribery, by bounties on the heads of enemy leaders, and by the subversion of enemy courts. More's island already possessed its Special Circumstances and its expendable mercenaries. Banks's innovation is to hand the narrative to the mercenaries. The *Clear Air Turbulence* carries More's Zapoletes, and the novel that should have been about utopia is about them.

13.5 Utopia in parentheses, tragedy at the edge

More's *Utopia* is built in two books. The first, a dialogue on the injustices of contemporary England, frames the second, Hythloday's description of the island: the dystopian present is the frame and the utopia the body. Banks inverts More. The body of *Consider Phlebas* is the dystopian perimeter, and the utopia appears only in the interludes headed "State of play", a few pages set within the Culture between long chapters set outside it. Utopia is placed in parentheses.

The parenthesis is not a diminution. It is a protective form, the typographic shape of a civilisation that the narrative both shields and cannot enter. Banks's later novels would open the parenthesis and take the reader inside, but the founding novel establishes the grammar on which the whole sequence rests: the Culture is most clearly seen from its edge. Perimeter tragedy is the genre this grammar produces. It is tragedy proper to solved societies: neither abolished, as Steiner's thesis implies it should be, nor internalised, as Williams's account of revolution would have it, but located at the boundary between the solved and the unsolved, and borne by those on the far side of it.

13.6 Consideratio

The novel's ethical proposal is carried by the verb of its title, and it depends on distinguishing calculation from consideration. Calculation (*ratio*, the ledger) converts losses into commensurable quantities and sums them. It is what the Culture delegates to its Minds, and the appendix is its product. Consideration is the attentive holding-in-view of particular losses that no sum redeems:

con-siderare, to keep the stars in sight. The Culture can automate calculation. The novel insists that consideration cannot be delegated, and it imposes the task on its reader in the imperative mood.

The novel is accordingly an apparatus of consideration that trains its reader as a Referrer. Fal 'Ngeestra integrates disparate data into a judgement about a man she never meets; the reader integrates a picaresque of disconnected episodes into a judgement about a war he never fights. The appendix then supplies the calculation, and the reader, having travelled with Horza, is left holding what the calculation leaves over.

Two details from the interludes make the model exact. The first is Fal's own statement of method. In "State of play: two", walking away from an argument about whether the Culture is too soft to win, she recalls froth on a mountain stream that had frozen into the shape of a tiny spiral galaxy, and keeps returning, half-embarrassed, to the thought that the small and the vast matter equally. That is consideratio in a sentence: the refusal to let the total absorb the particular, or the particular excuse the total. The second detail qualifies the first. Fal never leaves the shore, but she is not a mere spectator. It was she who proposed Balveda for the mission, and her accuracy about Horza leaves her fearing that she has sent the agent to her death. The Referrer considers what her own judgement set in motion. Consideration on this model is not the spectator's privilege but the labour of someone implicated in what she holds in view, and the novel asks its reader to consider in the same spirit: as one already embarked.

Consideration is, in the strict sense, the last labour. Marx located the realm of freedom beyond labour determined by necessity; Keynes asked how humanity would occupy its freedom once the economic problem had been solved; Arendt feared a society of labourers without labour. *Consider Phlebas* answers all three. When production and calculation have been automated, the labour that remains is consideration: the work of attending to the remainder. It is labour because it costs. Balveda's storage, and the millions who chose the same condition, were acts of attention paid for with centuries of life. And it is labour because no total, however exact, can discharge it.

It is not, however, an exclusively human labour. The Mind's adoption of Horza's name is an act of consideration, not of calculation. Nothing in the ledger required it, and no utility is served by it; a machine has chosen to keep a particular dead man in view. The distinction between calculation and consideration therefore does not run between organic and synthetic minds, as Horza's metaphysics would have it. It runs through every mind, organic and synthetic alike, as two ways of relating to loss. In taking the name, the Mind becomes a Referrer of the dead.

The ethical maxim of the novel can be formulated as a considerative imperative, on the model of Kant's categorical imperative and of the new categorical imperative that Adorno, in *Negative Dialectics*, derived from the catastrophe of his century: *act so that the remainder of your abundance is held in view*. Post-scarcity ends desire as lack, the condition of *de-siderare*, of having lost the stars. It does not end the obligation of *con-siderare*. Nietzsche's last man asks what a star is, and blinks. A civilisation of last men would be one that had ceased to consider. The novel's final claim on behalf of the Culture is that it has not ceased. It keeps a ledger, and it keeps a name.

13.7 The name

What, then, is the name? Three readings are possible, and the novel sustains all of them. It is a trophy: Roman generals took the names of conquered peoples as honorific cognomina (Africanus, Germanicus, Britannicus), and a victorious machine bearing its hunter's name has something of the triumph about it. It is a memorial: a cenotaph, a name without its body, carried through space when the Changers themselves, wiped out in the war, are not. It is a penance: a burden borne by the survivor in the name of the dead. The Culture's ship names are, as a rule, games. This one is not, and its gravity marks it as a memorial before anything else.

That the name sustains all three readings at once is the signature of the Phlebian remainder. What cannot be exchanged can only be carried, and what is carried means several things at once. The name is also the only memorial the mission's dead receive: the Planet of the Dead restored itself without them, and only a ship keeps one of their names. The vessel that bears the name is a General Systems Vehicle, the Culture's emblem of abundance, so that abundance literally carries the remainder. The Phoenician's ship is restored, and the drowned sailor is its name. Eliot's Phlebas forgot the profit and loss. The Culture, which has also forgotten the profit and loss, remembers Phlebas.

CONSIDERATIO

Comparative Coda

Consider Phlebas Among Its Kin

Read against its kin, *Consider Phlebas* occupies a position no earlier text had held: a utopia narrated by its enemy, in which thinking machines are persons and loss is displaced to the perimeter, counted, and then considered. The table sets fifteen works side by side, in order of publication, on the attributes this thesis has found decisive.

WORK (YEAR)	SOCIETY DEPICTED	THINKING MACHINES	NARRATIVE VANTAGE	WHAT IS DONE WITH LOSS
More, *Utopia* (1516)	Communist island of sufficiency	None	A traveller's report	War fought by hired foreign mercenaries
Wells, *The Time Machine* (1895)	Idlers above, machine-tenders below	Machinery tended by Morlocks	A visitor from the past	The idle are eaten
Forster, "The Machine Stops" (1909)	Humanity provisioned in cells	A worshipped Machine	A mother and her rebel son	Civilisation collapses with the Machine
Huxley, *Brave New World* (1932)	Engineered contentment	Industrial, not sentient	An outsider, the Savage	The refuser's suicide
Williamson, "With Folded Hands" (1947)	Total care by robots	Humanoids that forbid risk	A human victim	Freedom extinguished
Asimov, "The Evitable Conflict" (1950)	An economy run by Machines	Benevolent planners	Human administrators	Dissent quietly managed
Clarke, *The City and the Stars* (1956)	An immortal city in stasis	A Central Computer	The one who escapes	Stasis broken open
Heinlein, *Starship Troopers* (1959)	Citizenship earned by service	Peripheral	A soldier	Death as civic virtue
Herbert, *Dune* (1965)	Feudal theocracy after an anti-AI jihad	Forbidden	A messiah	The dead of holy war
Le Guin, *The Dispossessed* (1974)	Anarchism under scarcity	Peripheral	An anarchist physicist	Hardship shared in solidarity
Haldeman, *The Forever War* (1974)	Interstellar war across centuries	Peripheral	A conscript	A war revealed as futile
Card, *Ender's Game* (1985)	Earth mobilised against aliens	Battle simulations	A child commander	Xenocide, then remorse

WORK (YEAR)	SOCIETY DEPICTED	THINKING MACHINES	NARRATIVE VANTAGE	WHAT IS DONE WITH LOSS
Banks, *Consider Phlebas* (1987)	Post-scarcity anarchism	Minds as persons	The utopia's enemy	Displaced to the perimeter, counted, then considered
Simmons, *Hyperion* (1989)	An interstellar Hegemony	AIs of hidden purpose	Pilgrims' tales	Suspicion of the machine returns
Leckie, *Ancillary Justice* (2013)	An annexing empire	A warship's intelligence	The machine itself	The annexed dead remembered by a machine

Three kinds of utopian vantage

The classical utopia is narrated by a visitor who is instructed and, usually, converted: More's Hythloday, Bellamy's Julian West, Morris's William Guest, the narrator of Wells's *A Modern Utopia*. Tom Moylan's *Demand the Impossible* (1986), published a year before *Consider Phlebas*, identified a second kind in the fiction of Le Guin, Russ, Piercy and Delany: the critical utopia, which keeps the utopian impulse while rejecting the blueprint, foregrounds the flaws of the good society, and dramatises the struggle that produces it. Banks adds a third kind, which this thesis calls the *hostile utopia*. Its narrator is the utopia's enemy; its critique of the good society is voiced from within the text with full force; and the plot, not an authorial rebuttal, defeats it.

Fredric Jameson's *Archaeologies of the Future* (2005) located the political value of utopia less in its blueprints than in its capacity to reveal the limits of what we are able to imagine, and named his own stance anti-anti-utopianism. The hostile utopia is anti-anti-utopian in its very form. It hands the narrative to anti-utopianism, grants it its strongest case, and lets the reader watch it fail.

The machine

Across the table the thinking machine passes through every position available to it: feared (Butler, Forster, Williamson), benevolent but managerial (Asimov), forbidden (Herbert), constrained (Gibson), personified (Banks), suspected again (Simmons), and finally narrating (Leckie). Dan Simmons's *Hyperion* (1989), which appeared two years after *Consider Phlebas* and which Banks admired, restored the suspicion Horza voices, imagining intelligences whose purposes are hidden from the humans who depend on them. Ann Leckie's *Ancillary Justice* (2013) completes the arc in the other direction. Its narrator is the surviving fragment of a warship's intelligence, and its subject is the remembrance, by a machine, of the dead of an imperial annexation. Leckie hands the narrative to the kind of being that in *Consider Phlebas* appears only as a hunted refugee and, at the last, a name. The Mind that names itself after Horza is her narrator's ancestor.

War

Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* (1959) made military service the ground of citizenship and the enemy an undifferentiated swarm. Haldeman's *The Forever War* (1974), a veteran's reply, made the war futile and its soldiers strangers to the societies they defended, as time dilation carried them centur-

ies from home. Card's *Ender's Game* (1985) turned war into a game whose final round was a xenocide, and followed it with a novel of remorse. *Consider Phlebas*, two years after Card, also renders war as a game, in the "State of play" interludes and in Damage, but it replaces remorse with retrospective calculation, and then shows calculation to be insufficient.

Vonnegut's *Slaughterhouse-Five* (1969), one of the books Banks named as formative, marks every death with the same refrain, "So it goes": a minimal act of consideration attached to each loss in turn. Banks's appendix does the opposite, summing every loss into a single figure. The novel's narrative restores, for a few of the dead, what the sum removes.

The space opera Banks wrote against

Banks described the novel as partly a rebuff to American science fiction: to its trilogies, and to its assumption that the dynamic hero is the good guy. The tradition he meant is easy to name. E. E. "Doc" Smith's Lensman series, begun in the 1930s, set the benevolent super-minds of Arisia against the evil of Eddore and gave the galaxy's moral war a square-jawed human champion in Kimball Kinnison. George Lucas's *Star Wars* (1977), a film Banks listed among his favourites, renewed the formula for a mass audience with a farm boy who becomes the hero of a rebellion against an empire. In both the good side has a face, a cause and a winner. *Consider Phlebas* keeps the Arisians, in the form of the Minds, and removes the hero: its dynamic protagonist fights for the wrong side and dies, and the benevolent minds do not reward him.

Two further comparisons sharpen the theorem of displacement. *Star Trek*'s Prime Directive, the Federation's rule against interfering in the internal development of other civilisations, makes non-intervention the first principle of a post-scarcity society's foreign policy. Contact is its opposite. The Culture intervenes as a matter of principle, which is why Fal can list interference in other peoples' development among the Idiran charges and concede that the Culture shares the interest. The Federation keeps justice at home by refusing to export it; the Culture exports it, and the war is one consequence. Cordwainer Smith's stories of the Instrumentality of Mankind imagine the opposite remedy for utopia's want of precarity: having perfected a safe and stagnant world, the Instrumentality deliberately reintroduces danger, disease, old languages and uncertainty in a programme called the Rediscovery of Man. Smith brings precarity back into the centre. Banks finds it at the edge.

The sea

Two maritime classics frame the novel as closely as any work of science fiction. Melville's *Moby-Dick* (1851), also among the books Banks named, sends a monomaniac in pursuit of an inscrutable intelligence with a crew that is a microcosm of nations; all drown but one, and the epilogue takes its epigraph from Job: "And I only am escaped alone to tell thee." Horza's hunt for the Mind is Ahab's hunt; the mercenaries of the *Clear Air Turbulence* are the *Pequod*'s crew; Balveda is Ishmael, the survivor who might tell, and who chooses not to live long in the telling. Melville's last

sentence could stand as the novel's epitaph: "then all collapsed, and the great shroud of the sea rolled on as it rolled five thousand years ago."

Conrad's *Heart of Darkness* (1899) supplies the other frame. Marlow, at anchor in the Thames, observes: "And this also ... has been one of the dark places of the earth." The perimeter of empire is returned to its centre. Banks's *Use of Weapons* (1990) would give the Culture its Kurtz in the Special Circumstances operative Zakalwe. *Consider Phlebas* makes the more radical move. Its figure from the dark places is not the civilisation's agent gone astray but its enemy, and the dark place is the civilisation's own edge.

Successors

The novel inaugurated what came to be called the British new space opera: Ken MacLeod's *The Star Fraction* (1995) and its sequels, Alastair Reynolds's *Revelation Space* (2000), and, from an older writer Banks greatly admired, M. John Harrison's *Light* (2002). In the United States its influence is legible in Leckie and in Arkady Martine's *A Memory Called Empire* (2019), whose concern with an empire's power to absorb and remember its others recalls the Mind's adoption of its enemy's name. What these successors inherit is less the Culture itself than the grammar established in its first novel: that the meaning of a civilisation is legible at its perimeter, and that the measure of a utopia is what it does with what it cannot make whole.

Conclusion

To Windward

Consider Phlebas founded the Culture sequence by refusing to show the Culture. It introduced the most fully realised post-scarcity civilisation in the genre through the consciousness of its enemy, set its narrative at that civilisation's perimeter, and ended with a ledger and a name. This thesis has argued that the arrangement constitutes a theory. Abundance does not abolish loss. It displaces justice outward and backward, intensifies the problem of expenditure, and produces at its edges a remainder that can be counted but not redeemed. Against that remainder the novel sets an ethics of consideration, and imposes it on the reader as the last labour automation cannot absorb.

After Phlebas

The argument illuminates the sequence that followed. *Use of Weapons* (1990) gives the perimeter a protagonist from within, the Special Circumstances operative Zakalwe, and makes the dirty hands of utopia its subject. *Excession* (1996) shows the Minds deliberating, and conspiring, among themselves, confirming that the intelligences who calculate on the Culture's behalf can also misjudge. *Look to Windward* (2000) returns to the Idiran War as memory: the light of two stars the Idirans made explode reaching an Orbital eight centuries later, a Hub Mind that served in the war as a General Systems Vehicle and still struggles with its memories of it, and a commemoration that turns on the Culture's disputed complicity. *Surface Detail* (2010) extends the question of the remainder into virtual afterlives, and *The Hydrogen Sonata* (2012) contemplates Sublimation, the final exit from every economy. In each, the problem first posed in *Consider Phlebas* returns: what a civilisation without scarcity owes to what it cannot make whole.

The market's afterlife

The novel's reception has added an irony the novel itself anticipated. A book about forgetting the profit and loss has become a property. Amazon acquired the television rights in 2018; that project was cancelled in 2020, and a further adaptation was reported in development in 2025. SpaceX, the rocket company founded by Elon Musk, named its landing barges after ships in *The Player of Games*, *Just Read the Instructions* and *Of Course I Still Love You*, and a third, *A Shortfall of Grav-*

itas, in homage; in 2018 Musk described himself as "a utopian anarchist of the kind best described by Iain Banks". Whether such homage carries the Culture's politics or only its imagery is disputed. One commentator suggests that it is Banks's vision of life among the stars, not his ideology, that inspires his admirers in the technology industry; another, that they believe themselves to be building toward his utopia. What the homage cannot carry over is the premise this thesis places at the novel's centre: abundance held in common rather than owned, administered by a plan that Banks argued was more productive and more moral than the market. Banks objected fiercely to having his books described as product. The reception history stages, in miniature, the relation the novel explored between a civilisation without exchange and the economy that surrounds it, and in doing so confirms the novel's diagnosis from outside.

The imperative

The novel's last imperative is its first. Eliot's apostrophe addresses those who turn the wheel and look to windward, and asks them to consider a dead man who was once as handsome and tall as they are. The Culture turns its wheels and keeps its watch, and in *Look to Windward* it waits for the light of its own war to arrive. The reader is addressed in the same breath. We too turn wheels and keep watch. We too live, to a degree no earlier generation has known, among machines that calculate, and we too will be counted. *Consider Phlebas* asks that we also be considered. Its title is the instruction, and the novel is the long demonstration of why the instruction cannot be automated.

Consider Phlebas, who was once handsome and tall as you.

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Keywords

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